The Shadows Within

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Original Child Character(s), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Future Fic, POV Adora (She-Ra), Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Mental Health Issues, Depression, Shame, Self-Worth Issues, Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Self-Destruction, Suicidal Thoughts, Psychological Trauma, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Unreliable Narrator

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by NotMyDestiny

Summary

Adora has been trying to hold everything together in her life at Bright Moon with Catra and their three kids, but lately things are feeling complicated and chaotic. As sleepless nights turn to haunted days and shame curdles into silence, a shadow is rising from the cracks that might put Adora and everything she loves at risk.

Chapter 1

Clangs of weapons and grunts of exertion cut through the air as Adora's team of guards completed their training exercise under her careful guidance, in an all too familiar rhythm of her life. The soft rustle of a breeze carried the usual combined smells of sweat, grass and metal across the training yard. The first hints of dusk were starting to settle across the Bright Moon grounds as Adora looked out across the sky and caught a glimpse of rainbow wings fluttering past as Swift Wind circled routinely overhead.

As usual, it had been a demanding day for all, and Adora was grateful the work was coming to a close. She forced her shoulders back and smoothed her expression; her gray compression top and pants were practical but looked sharp, and her golden hair with a few wisps of silver was slicked back into a smooth bun at the nape of her neck, ever the picture of command. She called out crisply to her team, "Attention. Unit dismissed."

The last exercise of the day was now complete, and they could all head back to their quarters or to dinner as they preferred. As they headed out, Adora replayed the events of the day. She thought she could see some small improvements in her team's performance, but maybe that was just what she needed to tell herself.

Adora rubbed unconsciously at the back of her neck, her body filled with a lingering mix of adrenaline and fatigue from a long day overseeing drills, coordinating schedules, and assigning tasks and patrols. She had worked diligently as always to balance managing the needs of her team of guards along with reporting in to her own leadership. Together, they all worked as a carefully coordinated unit to keep things safe and in order for Bright Moon and all the kingdoms of Etheria.

Adora stepped into the castle. The air was cooler here, but still abuzz with end-of-day activity. Messengers carried reports, and aides hurried from one hall to another with thick stacks of

parchment. It was clear that everyone was busy and working hard, and as one of Bright Moon's top senior guards, Adora knew it was part of her job to be reliable and strong for everyone.

As Adora walked briskly toward her family quarters, she saw Glimmer and Bow approaching. Light reflected off Glimmer's circlet crown woven through her closely cropped waves, and she looked every bit the dedicated Queen. Bow, right beside her, radiated his cheerfulness as steady as ever. They smiled warmly at one another, even as Adora felt a small pang of guilt at how little time they were spending together these days.

"Adora, how are you?" Bow called out brightly.

"I'm doing pretty well, Bow," Adora said a beat too fast, her smile a bit too forced. "My guards had a decent day of training, and I'm heading back now to see Catra and the kids," Adora replied with warmth, though some of her tiredness slipped through.

Glimmer nodded along, "Same with us. We're all always so busy. It seems like we just never really have time anymore to spend together."

Adora nodded in agreement. She missed them, but there was always so much to do these days. "Yeah, we just keep moving forward, right? We're all just doing our best, and everything is going well enough, so we'll just keep doing what we can."

Bow smiled, "Say hi to Catra and the kids from us. We'll get together again soon."

"Yeah. Soon." Adora replied, though it felt a bit like a lie. Already, the thought of trying to make a solid plan was sliding away beneath the weight of everything else she needed to manage for her family and her guards. Adora continued on down the hall, realizing it was easier to just keep smiling than to try and explain how she was always feeling like she was running behind these days.

Adora opened the door to her family's suite only to find another type of chaos. The noise crested like a wave about to crash, and she felt her shoulders tighten as if ready for impact. The rattle of metallic puzzle pieces and the building crescendo of whines and snipes echoed through the main room. The clutter of toys and art supplies littered the floor.

Finn was curled on the couch with their ears flicking irritably at all the loud voices. Cole had pieces of a mechanical puzzle scattered all across the floor and was trying to get Rosra to work on it with him, but Rosra was not having it. Instead, Rosra was distracted and scowling at a drawing that wasn't coming out like she had imagined it in her head. Melog was stretched out between the kids on the floor, alternately nudging Rosra and Cole softly with its head, trying to help calm their rising emotions, though it wasn't doing much good at the moment.

Cole was calling out loudly over and over for Rosra to help him with the puzzle.

Rosra was loudly refusing with a string of "Nos." She then threw a crayon so hard it snapped in half as she shouted, "This picture is ugly, and I hate it."

Adora took in the scene from the doorway with a slow exhale as she felt Catra entering beside her with her own arms full of a stack of parchments that she carefully set down on a desk. Catra, her dark hair tied back stylishly in a crisp burgundy blouse and slacks, then quickly knelt by Rosra and said, "Hey, claws in. Crayons aren't your enemy."

Rosra crossed her arms, her ginger tail lashing, and her bright yellow eyes brimming with tears.

Meanwhile, Cole complained, "She never really helps with puzzles. She just quits!"

Finn grimaced, ears flattening into the strands of their golden blond hair as they said softly, "Could everyone please stop

yelling?”

Paused at the door and a bit slow to respond, Adora blinked and then slid down beside Cole, ruffling his copper hair. She took a breath and tried to project calm. “Hey, you’ve been doing a great job with this puzzle so far. Can you show me your work?”

Cole’s golden eyes lit up, and he immediately launched into an excited explanation. Adora tried her best to give him her full attention even as the day’s exhaustion tugged at her. To the kids, she was the steady mom they relied on, but inside, she was beginning to feel like a fraying rope that was being pulled too tight.

Nearby, Catra had pulled Rosra into her lap to let her softly cry out her frustrations in a hug. “I know it didn’t turn out how you wanted,” Catra murmured in a soothing tone. “That is so frustrating, but that doesn’t mean you’re bad at it, okay?“

Rosra sniffled and clung to her even more.

Catra had eased into the chaos so naturally. She always seemed to have the needed balance of sharpness and grace that any situation required. Watching her, Adora felt a mix of adoration, relief, and a twinge of inadequacy. Somehow, Catra always seemed to know how to handle these situations where Adora felt inadequate, like it was just less instinctual for her somehow.

Finn eased off the couch and knelt beside Adora. They didn’t say anything, but Adora gave their shoulder a small squeeze, and her heart filled with love. She realized the kids were finally settling under their attention and care. Adora met Catra’s gaze across the room, both of them tired and stretched thin after long days of work, but still connected.

Catra gave her a small smile and said, “Remind me why we thought three was a good number?”

Adora laughed softly and said, “Because we’re hopelessly in love and thought we could handle anything.” Her laughter had come

easier than she had expected, real if a bit brittle from the complexities of the day.

Catra grinned widely, “Yeah, that tracks.”

Despite the noise and demands of their family and kingdom, there was no mistaking the warmth that filled the room. Their kids could be loud and unpredictable, but they were also curious and so deeply loved. In the midst of the overwhelm, Adora and Catra’s devotion to each other and their children held things together. In these moments, surrounded by papers and puzzles and crayons, they weren’t leaders or strategists but just parents. Their family might be messy and chaotic, but it was wholly theirs.

Dusk was settling, and Adora leaned back against the wall, her heart full but her body heavy. She felt a lingering tension deep inside her that wouldn’t release, even with the love all around her. She knew tomorrow would come early with all its challenges as it always did.



Chapter 2

It was mid-morning, and the training yard was winding down as a last set of drills wrapped up before the start of the next rotation. The rhythmic thud of boots in formation echoed, and the distant sounds of weapon sparring carried from across the field. A swirl of dirt had kicked up from constant movements as Adora walked amongst her team of guards, the grass crunching beneath her feet and the glare of light reflecting off their armor. She could taste the saltiness of sweat in the air. She gave small corrections that were firm but kind. Once again, she noted that Ryn, her newest guard, was having trouble keeping focused and needed near constant adjustments.

"That's enough for today. You've all done well. Take a water break before the next rotation." Adora commanded smoothly. She knew that they were all trying their best. She even managed a small, encouraging smile at Ryn.

Amidst the clatter of gear being stowed as her squad of guards dispersed, Adora saw Commander Minna, her always composed colleague who oversaw the overall training rotations, approaching for a word near the edge of the yard. Adora felt herself tensing a bit, and she took a deep breath and forced her shoulders to ease; no need to get riled up for a simple conversation.

Minna's crisp voice cut across the air between them, "Your unit's shaping up well, Adora. But I wanted to talk about Ryn."

Adora nodded curtly.

"I've noticed his repeated lapses of attention. Today, he crossed into another unit's perimeter and disrupted their practice."

"Yes, I know. I corrected him for that, but I can see now that he might need even more support," Adora replied, her thoughts already slipping toward times when she should have done more, replaying and cataloging all these past moments.

Minna nodded and added, “There’s really only so much you can do for him, Adora. He needs to take responsibility for his own progress.”

Adora understood that on a fundamental level, but still, as his main mentor and advocate, she couldn’t help feeling like she had somehow failed to provide the right type of guidance. That she hadn’t been the type of commander he needed, someone who would be able to help him push past these issues.

“Also, Adora,” Minna continued, “I heard that the General’s Council was reviewing reports earlier, and your name came up in the discussion. Just wanted to let you know in advance.”

Adora’s heart dropped into her stomach as she willed herself to appear composed.

“Thanks, Minna, I appreciate that,” she managed to reply even as she felt herself tensing again, her chest tightening and her shoulders clenching.

Exhaling sharply, trying to center herself, Adora headed determinedly back to the middle of the yard. It was probably nothing, and she needed to focus on the task at hand. She guided her guards through their next rotation, fixedly keeping her attention from drifting too far. Instead, she focused on just doing what she could to train them the best way possible in this moment.

When the rotation ended, Adora was not surprised to be called into a briefing room with General Juliet, but that didn’t prevent her unease. She headed toward the castle, the laughter of the guards fading in the distance, her shoulders aching from how she was holding them so straight. The light shifted from daylight to cool, crystal-lit brightness as she entered the castle atrium. Her boots echoed off the polished floor as she walked the corridor alone, her shadow taller beside her than she felt.

As Adora entered the small briefing room, General Juliet handed her a hot cup of tea, stating with both formality and kindness, “Good afternoon, Commander.”

“Good afternoon to you as well, General,” Adora replied a bit stiffly, feeling her pulse rate increasing.

Adora cradled the mug, trying to let its heat fortify her, even as the stark light glaring down from the overhead crystal fixture and the stiff back of the chair pushed against her, setting her more on edge. Parchments rustled as Juliet pulled up a report and slid it to Adora. The crisp edge of the paper pressed into her palm, and Adora scanned it, quickly trying to refamiliarize herself with the decisions of that day.

“Adora, the Council had a review earlier of the latest field reports, and they noted that you had left a sector far too short-staffed.” General Juliet’s tone and expression seemed neutral, but Adora also read possible disappointment.

Adora tried to explain her approach calmly, “My understanding was that the Whispering Woods needed extra reinforcements due to an aggressive animal sighting.” She glanced at the notes in the report and then said, “I was not aware that Thaymor had requested additional patrols for a disturbance at their market.” Her voice began to falter at the end as she realized she may have made the wrong decision and put people at risk. The thumping of her heart increased, and she felt more on edge. She felt a headache starting at the base of her skull.

Juliet paused for a long moment, evaluating, then nodded sharply, “It sounds like you made the right call based on the intel you had. Just check more thoroughly next time, okay?”

“Of course. I should’ve caught that,” Adora choked out, trying to force more surety than she felt.

“Adora, you’re doing fine,” Juliet added.

“Yeah, fine,” Adora repeated back almost numbly. She noticed the mug still gripped tightly in her hand was untouched, and she took a sip of the now lukewarm tea, tasting its bitterness on her tongue. Her thoughts lingered on the missing intel and its implications. She worried that she really had made the wrong call and the far-reaching impact her decisions could have on the people of Etheria. She needed to get this right for them. There wasn’t room for errors.

The rest of the day passed for Adora in somewhat of a blur. She went through the motions of leading her guards through their tasks, but it felt almost as if someone else was doing it and not her. Her mind couldn’t quite move past the earlier encounters; she kept replaying them and thinking of how she should have been doing more all along to have prevented these issues before they had even appeared.

Sharpness only returned as she stepped through the threshold of her family suite, her arms loaded with steaming dishes freshly retrieved from the dining hall. Her rooms were, as usual, messy and alive with energy. Toys were scattered underfoot, and the clattering of more spilling somewhere nearby seemed to hit a nerve. Adora was definitely still wound up from her day. A now fixed tension had settled into her shoulders, and her headache still lingered. Melog pressed against her legs, but it didn’t settle her like it should.

Adora set the platters of food onto their table and rushed around the kitchen gathering up utensils and filling water glasses that she quickly placed around the food.

“Dinner is ready,” she called out, and Catra and the kids came over.

Adora sat in her usual spot and began doling out food. She served herself last. The food had smelled great, but as Adora took small bites, she found she could barely even taste it. All around her were the familiar noises of a family dinner. The clang of plates and utensils, the high-pitched eager voices overlapping, chair legs

scraping from small shifting bodies, Finn's tail unconsciously brushing her arm, Melog's fur shimmering faintly nearby, Rosra singing something off-key, all building up around Adora with quiet intensity.

Then water was flowing across the table.
Cole's small voice exclaimed, "I didn't mean to spill it!"

"You never mean to but that doesn't stop it from happening, does it?" The words seemed to escape from Adora in a sharp, frustrated snap before she could stop them.

Everyone seemed frozen for a beat, and Cole's golden eyes had gone wide.

"No, I didn't… Cole, I'm sorry. I didn't mean that," Adora stammered. Disbelief that she had let her frustrations out like that. Her chest felt hollow.

Catra looked a bit startled for a moment, but her tail wrapped around Adora's wrist in reassurance as she said softly, "Hey, breathe. It's just water."

"Yeah, yeah, of course," Adora muttered, willing herself to come back to a state of calm.

Catra ruffled Cole's hair and toweled up the water. The kids began to chatter again, and Adora just stared at her plate, letting them talk around her. Dinner ended, and Adora lingered on the cleanup as the rest of the family settled into evening activities. She then reengaged, but Adora felt a bit like she was experiencing everything from afar. She was interacting, but it felt like someone else was the one going through the motions.

Soon it was bedtime, and blankets were being tucked up tightly around small shoulders. Rosra's ears twitched against her cheek affectionately as Adora adjusted her blanket. Cole mumbled about finishing his puzzle tomorrow as his eyes drifted shut. Finn whispered goodnight and curled tighter under their blankets. This sweet and familiar rhythm should have soothed Adora, but

instead, she felt hollow. As she kissed each child, her motions felt rote and automatic, and she couldn't quite push away the thought that they deserved something more than she could give.

Dimmed lights cast long shadows across the walls. As she walked into their bedroom, Adora felt Catra's gaze on her, watching her quietly. Adora didn't break the silence because she didn't even know where she would start with trying to explain how she was feeling.

They readied for bed and lay beside each other. Catra wrapped an arm around Adora. The steady pressure should have felt comforting, but instead it seemed heavy.

"Long day?" Catra asked

"Every day's a long day," Adora stated softly in a way that seemed to halt any further discussion. She turned and pressed her face into her pillow, feigning exhaustion to escape the weight of needing to explain herself.

Adora lay there willing sleep to come, but instead her mind filled with a swirl of thoughts and questions. Her life was fine. It was good. She had accomplished a lot as a senior leader in the guard, always keeping Etheria safe. She had Catra and the kids. It was the perfect family. Yet it felt like she somehow didn't fit right in this life. She wasn't quite good enough for any of it. She couldn't provide what Catra needed, or the kids, or her guards. She tried so hard, but somehow she was just constantly struggling and missing the mark these days. She was meant to be the one everyone could rely on and depend on, a solid source of strength, but right now, she felt like she was just falling apart.

The soft sounds of Catra's rhythmic breathing beside her meant that her wife had fallen asleep, but Adora felt restless and unable to sleep herself with all these thoughts churning in her head. She stared up at the ceiling. Every small imperfection of the day replayed in her mind in a distressing loop, her chest tightening with inadequacy.

Moving carefully so as not to disturb Catra, Adora pushed up from the bed. Ever so quietly, she left their suite and walked down the empty hall to a small, nearby training room. It wasn't much, but there was a punching bag, and that was all Adora needed right now. She took a stance and let loose a few smooth hits. Letting the rhythm of her motions keep her thoughts at bay.

The repetitive thud of fists against leather was the only sound in the room now. Thud. Thud. Thud. She let out another series of quick jabs, letting the physical exertion dull her thoughts until she began to feel detached from them. Each hit reverberated through her arms.

She could see her shadow moving in quick, harsh bursts on the wall beside her in the dimly lit room. For a moment, it almost seemed like her shadow flickered unnaturally. Its shape melded, almost elongating, and it punched forward when she had paused.

Adora blinked for a moment, but then shook off that impossible thought and went back to it, punching in rhythm once more. She continued until the burn in her knuckles fully drove out the pain of her thoughts, and she felt nothing. Only then, late into the night, did she towel off her sweat and slip back into her quiet quarters and bed, now empty and exhausted enough to collapse into sleep.

Chapter 3

Another week had blurred by, much like the last one, with early mornings and late nights spent in the training room trying to chase away thoughts Adora didn't know how else to handle. She had gotten used to rising before dawn and hitting the punching bag before the first light of the day even brightened the windows. At this point, it seemed that the motions had become more muscle memory than her own will.

Now, the first hints of morning light drove Adora back to her family suite, knowing she needed to ready the kids for the day. She moved quickly through the kitchen, smooth floor beneath her feet and muted colors muddled around her as she pulled together and plated five servings of a light breakfast of fruit and toast, her motions well-practiced and automatic. She then went to wake the kids.

"Morning, Finn," Adora said softly as she brushed golden strands of hair back from their face, as they blinked up blearily. Cole was already halfway out of bed, chattering about something he wanted to build, while Rosra buried herself more deeply under her blankets. Adora called out, her tone a bit flat, "Breakfast is ready. Come and eat it."

The clatter of dishes, kids' voices overlapping, and Melog's paws padding across the floor filled the kitchen. Adora sank down beside the kids and forced herself to try and be present. Rosra complained that the toast was too brown, and Adora nodded, trying to look sympathetic. Cole asked endless questions about how stars were formed, and Adora handed him a science fact book. Finn, ears twitching, insisted they just wanted quiet, and Adora gave their shoulder a soft squeeze.

By the time Catra came in, tying her robe loosely around her waist, the kids were nearly finished eating. Adora straightened instinctively, like she could hide the constant weight that seemed to press on her shoulders these days.

“Morning,” Catra murmured, leaning down to kiss Adora’s cheek before heading to brew some tea. Her ears flicked as she glanced over the plates and the neatly packed satchels waiting by the door. “You’ve been busy.”

“Needed to be done,” Adora said a bit flatly. She forced a smile, brushing toast crumbs from Rosra’s shirt.

Catra’s gaze swept over Adora, lingering on her face, her posture, the stiffness in her shoulders, but she didn’t say anything more.

After a moment, Catra started chattering happily with the kids. Adora zoned out. The children were joyful, but Adora couldn’t quite feel it herself. It was as if she was watching through fogged-over glass, partially seeing some of it but not really feeling like a solid part of any of it.

Catra nudged Adora’s shoulder affectionately, “Etheria to Adora. You’ve been staring off for a solid minute. What’s going on in that head of yours?”

Adora jolted slightly at a touch she hadn’t anticipated. “Sorry, I just got distracted.”

Catra squeezed Adora’s hand as she passed her a mug of tea. “You were up early again,” Catra murmured with concern.

“Like every day lately,” Adora replied, still forcing a smile that didn’t reach her eyes at all.

Catra’s hand lingered on Adora’s back as she passed by her to grab a brush for Rosra’s hair.

Adora’s gaze drifted again, her eyes focusing on some faraway point.

Together, they managed to wrangle the kids through dressing, teeth-brushing, and packing their lesson materials. Catra coaxed Rosra into wearing pants, while Adora helped Cole double-check his puzzle box project. Finn lingered near the door, quiet as usual,

but they gave Adora's hand a squeeze as they headed out with the others to their lessons, following one of the palace aides.

As the door closed behind them, Catra lingered, watching Adora gather the empty dishes with shoulders drawn too tight. Catra leaned against the door, tail flicking with quiet concern. As Adora approached, Catra's tail curled over Adora's hip, as if she could tether her by sheer touch. Catra pressed against Adora's side and let her head rest on her shoulder.

With a sigh, Adora admitted, "It doesn't feel like I'm doing enough."

"It's enough for them and enough for me," Catra reassured, her hand cupping Adora's jaw and her thumb stroking affectionately.

Adora nodded, but she couldn't quite let herself believe it. "We'd better start our days," she added softly, somewhat resigned.

Catra nodded and pressed a quick kiss to Adora's temple before heading down the hall to her office. Adora moved the opposite way, out of the castle to the training yard. Her shadow seemed to drift a step behind.

The yard appeared muted to Adora, like the grass and sky had been slightly drained of color. She found she could barely feel the wind or the warmth of the day. She stood in the center of her guards, trying to project strength, control, authority; everything she'd been trained to embody. She led them through another drill and then another rotation. She moved with automatic precision, saying the right things without thought, but everything felt like it was blurring together. Even the clang of their blades beside her felt distant and dull.

Her shadow seemed to lag behind her again when she turned. Just for an instant, its silhouette looked taller and broader with flowing hair. Adora shook her head, blinking hard, and re-focused on her team.

She dismissed the guards early, saying she needed to check on something, though she couldn't explain what. She stood for a moment after they left, staring out at the horizon. The sky was bright, the day alive, but she felt dulled, like she was half a step out of sync with the world.

Then, she heard the unmistakable rush of wings and a whinny that was both dramatic and affectionate as Swift Wind swooped down beside her.

"Adora! I sense grave peril. The kingdom's joy levels have dropped to critical. Only one person can restore balance, with Smile Power!"

Adora nodded, her gaze still a bit unfocused as she said softly, "You're ridiculous."

Swift Wind looked a bit disappointed, "You're still not smiling. Do my powers fail me?"

Adora murmured, distracted, "Guess so. I've gotta go." She turned and headed back toward the castle.

"Hey Adora, is everyth…" Swift Wind's words cut off as he realized she had moved away.

Adora walked quickly through the halls, barely taking them in. She opened the door to her suite, which was quiet for once as the kids hadn't yet come home from their after-lesson activities. The late afternoon light slanted across the floor. Adora sank into a chair at the table and began to page through a half-finished report. Catra entered the suite with a basket of clean laundry. Her ears flicked as she turned to Adora, who was sitting slouched at the table, staring at her report but not really writing it.

"Hey Adora," Catra called, "Can you help me fold these? If we leave it, the kids are gonna tear through it and scatter socks all over the place again."

Adora rubbed at her forehead without looking up. “Can it wait? I’m just… I don’t know. I just don’t think I can do it right now.”

The words hung there, seeming heavier than Adora had expected. Catra’s tail stilled, and her grip on the basket tightened. “I don’t even know how to reach you anymore. You’re here, but it’s like you’ve been gone for days.” Her voice was laced with frustration. “You think this just magically gets done by itself?”

Adora blinked, startled, blue eyes meeting mismatched ones. “Catra, I just…” She trailed off, not sure how to explain or a way to best fix this.

But Catra was already setting the basket down harder than needed, the clothes inside shifting. Her dual-colored eyes burned, not with anger but with something deeper, a mix of hurt, frustration, and a deepening sadness.

“For a minute there,” Catra said, voice low, “I thought of just bailing. Walking out and letting you figure out what it’s like to hold everything together without me.”

The silence that followed was sharp as glass. Adora’s breath caught in her throat. She opened her mouth, but no words came out, just a small, distressed sound.

Catra shook her head, her ears flattened, and turned on her heel. The bedroom door swung open, then closed hard behind her, swallowing her steps as she walked away.

Adora sat frozen, and her chest ached. It was an ache that grew until her vision blurred. She pressed her hands against her eyes, but the tears slipped past anyway. Her shoulders curled inward as soft sobs broke free. The afternoon light still poured in, indifferent to her pain, shining across the basket of laundry that sat unfolded on the table.

The room felt too quiet with Catra gone. Adora sat there a moment longer, tears slipping freely now, and her throat tight.

She stared at the basket of laundry as she heard Catra's voice echoing, threatening to leave her.

Adora pushed herself up abruptly, the chair scraping, and rushed into the bedroom. Adora's eyes darted, and then she spotted Catra, sitting at the desk and rifling through papers, her tail flicking in restless frustration.

"Catra," Adora said softly, her voice breaking.

Catra turned, her mismatched eyes flashed for just a second, but then they softened immediately at the sight of Adora's tear-streaked face. The anger seemed to have drained out of her, replaced with something heavier and sadder.

Adora stepped closer, her hand half-lifted, hesitant to touch her. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean…"

But before she could finish, Catra's arms were around her. The hug was sudden and fierce as Catra pulled her in tight, like she was afraid now to let her go. Adora clutched her back in return, burying her face in her shoulder. For a long moment, neither of them said anything. They just held on to one another almost desperately.

When Catra finally spoke, her voice was rough. "I don't want to walk out. I was just…" She swallowed hard. "I hate that I said it like that. I don't mean it."

Adora's chest squeezed painfully. She whispered into her shoulder, "I hate that I made you feel that way. I should've helped. I just… sometimes everything just feels like too much, but I don't want you to end up taking it all on."

Catra pulled back enough to look at Adora, her expression softer now but still lined with sadness. She brushed her thumb gently over Adora's cheek. "I just don't want to feel like we're doing this alone when we're supposed to be in it together."

Adora nodded quickly, blinking back fresh tears. “You’re right. You’re always right.”

Catra threaded their fingers together. “Come on. Let’s just go and put away the dumb laundry together.”

And they did. They worked side-by-side at the table, folding shirts and pairing socks, the air quiet but no longer brittle. Their shoulders brushed now and then, grounding each other in the simple rhythm of the task.

As Adora folded, she couldn’t stop replaying their conversation in her mind over and over. It frightened her how easily Catra had said she’d thought about bailing, how raw and real that frustration had been. It swirled inside her, heavy and insistent. It whispered to her that she wasn’t enough, that she had driven Catra to the edge.

Even with Catra warm at her side, even with their hands brushing as they worked, Adora’s chest stayed tight. She forced a smile now and then for Catra’s sake, but inside she felt the weight of it pressing. She was gripped by fear that next time, Catra might mean it.

The evening passed by in a blur. Adora said and did all the right things, but it felt like someone else was the one doing it. She could barely even recall the kids coming home, grabbing dinner for them from the dining hall, crafts and puzzles and the bedtime routine. It all seemed to be happening in another, distant world.

Adora once more waited until Catra was asleep before she made her way to the now all too familiar training room and started in on another round of punches. She didn’t know how long she’d been doing this nightly. It might have been a week, maybe two. It all bled together in a blur of sweat and shadows.

The empty training room was dim, streaks of moonlight spilling across the floor. Adora moved through forms in silence, her

movements sharp but a bit unsteady. Tonight, the silence felt alive, and it seemed almost like she was being watched.

The leather of the punching bag creaked with each hit. Every sound felt amplified in the quiet. The echo of her fists, the catch of her breath, the shuffling of her feet against the hard floor all seemed loud. Her shadow seemed to move differently. Its stance was taller and its movements seemingly disjointed from her own.

Her punches got harder and faster. She whispered things to herself under her breath, "You have to do better. You can't fall apart now."

She realized she wasn't having just one bad day. It had been a whole string of them, each one heavier than the last, and she couldn't remember where the weight had started.

Her mind filled with Catra's echoing words and the closing of the bedroom door. She could see Rosra's tearful scowl, Cole's slumped shoulders, Finn retreating into silence. Then Ryn's desperate need for better guidance and the faces of citizens of Etheria let down by a bad call all flashed through her mind.

Adora found herself training even more intensely. Sweat ran down her neck, and her muscles burned as she tried to drive herself past the point of feeling. Her shadow lengthened unnaturally behind her, stretching toward her with each swing. As the physical pain started to replace the emotional pain, Adora fixated on that pain as proof she could still be strong.

The air felt charged and prickled her skin. A static-like hum filled the air. Her shadow against the wall had sharpened, shoulders broader, hair longer and flowing in full She-Ra form.

And then, her shadow stepped forward, lifting free from the wall. It was dark, alive, and cruelly calm. She-Ra's glowing eyes flashed faintly in it.

For a breathless moment, they just looked at each other. Then Adora staggered back, heart pounding, as she whispered, "No…

no, that’s not real.”

A voice layered with echoes of Adora’s own said lowly, “Fix yourself… or I’ll finish the job.”

Adora raised her fist, and Shadow She-Ra did the same. Adora struck suddenly, her blow hitting nothing, but the force of Shadow She-Ra’s mirrored punch knocked Adora back, and she hit the ground, gasping.

The shadow vanished.

The room was empty now, except for Adora. She was trembling, her breath ragged. She told herself she was exhausted, that she must have imagined it, but the faint scorch mark of a footprint remained on the ground where the shadow had stood.



Chapter 4

The training room was silent now. The only sound was Adora's pounding heartbeat, loud in her ears. Sweat was drying cold on her back, and she felt the tremor of her exhausted muscles and the faint, lingering pang of tenderness in her ribs where the shadow had struck her, more reminder than injury. As she sat, hunched on the cold floor, the words of the shadow rang in her head, "Fix yourself."

Fine, Adora could do that. She had to do it. She just needed to be better for everyone. If she tried harder, she was sure she could just fix things. She was strong. She could be even stronger if needed. The thoughts felt thin, almost fragile, but they steadied her all the same. By the time her resolve had settled into place, the first hints of daylight began to creep across the room.

Steeling herself with a few deep, steadying breaths, Adora headed back to her family suite. She was intent now on being the version of herself that she knew everyone needed. She would be helpful and steady, and ready for anything.

She opened the door quietly. The ever-present clutter of puzzle pieces, art supplies, games and toys was littered about the floor as usual. Adora knelt amongst the muddle of toys and picked up and sorted through them until everything was in order as the faint light of dawn strengthened around her.

With that task completed, Adora left the suite to head to the dining hall and quickly returned with a tray of fresh, steaming dishes, a sweet smell rising off the hot platters. She set everything out on the table, creating a picture-perfect scene. She could do this. She was determined to make things better.

Approaching the kids' beds, Adora called out with all the cheer she had in her, "Good morning, I got honeycakes for breakfast!"

That announcement roused the kids a bit faster than usual, as they were always excited for a treat.

“Honeycakes for real?” Rosra squealed, her yellow eyes bright and her ears twitching with excitement, as she rose from her bed instead of burrowing in like usual.

“It’s not even a rest day!” Cole exclaimed as he too bounced out of bed, his copper fur mussed, and Finn was right beside him.

As they gathered around the table, light flooded in bright and sharp from the nearest window, glinting off the freshly scrubbed surfaces. Catra, hearing the cheerful commotion, quickly joined them, still looking a bit rumpled from sleep. Adora passed her a steaming mug of tea and kissed her cheek.

“Wow, Adora. How did you have time to do all of this?” Catra’s mismatched eyes were wide as she took in the pristine room.

“Just trying to start the day off well,” Adora replied, her tone a little too bright and her smile practically glued in place.

Adora moved with restless precision, waiting on everyone’s needs, her movements brisk and a little too sharp as she tried to get everything just right. She wiped away nonexistent crumbs, refilled cups that were still partly full, and passed around more napkins in a flurry of motion. The kids ate and chattered happily, oblivious to her need to carry and control every detail and make things perfect.

Catra’s eyes followed her around the kitchen as she said gently, “Hey, sit for a minute with us.”

Adora replied with more forced cheer, “I’m just keeping everything moving along.”

Catra gave her a look that was half fond and half uneasy.

The two worked together, as usual, in a well-practiced routine to get the kids ready for their lessons and out the door with the

palace aide. As Catra pulled up Rosra's ginger waves into a ponytail, Adora wiped a smudge of honey off her cheek. Adora made sure to give each of the kids a kiss on the forehead and a tight squeeze as she called out to them with extra brightness, "I love you all. Have the best day!"

The door closed, leaving the suite quiet without the kids' constant chatter. The faint smell of honey lingered in the air, sweet and almost cloying. Catra leaned back against the door and gave Adora a long, lingering look as if trying to see into her mind.

"You gonna tell me what's going on?" Catra asked finally, her voice soft and curious, not accusing.

Still, Adora felt a bit startled, as she thought she had been doing everything just right. Her reply was hesitant and a bit anxious, "What do you mean? I..I just wanted a good morning for them, for you."

Catra gave her a soft smile and cupped her cheek lightly as she reassured, "It was a good morning for all of us." Then, with concern building in her eyes, she added, "You look tired, Adora."

"I'm okay," Adora replied quickly, forcing a smile that couldn't quite meet her eyes. Her hand rubbed the back of her neck absentmindedly as she stammered, "I... I've gotta get to the yard. I don't want to be late. I need everything to be ready for the guards today." She kissed Catra's cheek without meeting her eyes and stepped through the threshold. She then rushed down the hall, her boots thudding against the polished floor.

Adora managed to arrive at the yard first. Her footsteps crunching across the crisp grass as she carefully prepared for the first rotation, setting out weapons and dummies and arranging everything just so. She was going to do this right today.

Ryn arrived and greeted her calmly, "Morning, Commander."

Adora smiled a bit tightly as she replied, "Morning. We'll get started in just a few moments."

The other guards arrived, and Adora addressed them, "Alright, we'll start with a standard drill sequence as a warm-up."

"Attention! Fall in!" Adora called out with authority as the guards quickly aligned around her. "We'll run through our standard formation sequence: line, wedge, column, file, vee."

Zira spoke up a bit hesitantly, "Commander, our sequence is usually line, column, wedge, vee, file."

"Right. Of course," Adora replied steadily, even as she felt her stomach twist. She was already getting it wrong, and the day had barely started. She took a deep breath in through her nose and forced those thoughts away. She would do better. Be better. She was determined.

They completed their initial formations and drills, and Adora directed them through their morning rotations without further issue. They took a break for lunch, the guards heading to the dining hall, while Adora returned briefly to her suite to complete some paperwork she needed to do while she ate.

Returning to the yard, Adora ran her guards through a series of weapon drills. Dust swirled up into the air where boots scuffed against the packed ground, catching in Adora's throat. Her grip tightened on her sword hilt. She tried to make a correction and gave the wrong command. A guard hesitated, and there was a soft clang of a minor bump of armor against armor.

The mistake was small, really barely worth noticing. However, to Adora, it felt enormous, proof of the thing she feared most, that she was failing them. Her thoughts began to swirl. She should be better than this. She had done this a thousand times. Why was she getting it wrong? She was supposed to fix herself. Why weren't her efforts working?

A heaviness pressed on her chest, a sadness rising within her, but she quickly pushed it back with slow, deep breaths. Her gaze drifted down. Her shadow stretched out before her across the

grass. It moved in time with her. Then, for a fraction of a second, her shadow hesitated like it was a half-beat behind her movement before it jerked to catch up. Her breath caught, and her pulse quickened with a sense of creeping dread. The clang of the yard faded with every sound seemingly dropping into slow motion. Adora shifted her stance, watching carefully. Her shadow mirrored her perfectly this time. Still, a heaviness remained tight in her chest.

She took a stuttering breath and forced herself to focus and keep it together. Adora vowed to herself that she could still do this right. She could still fix herself and be who they needed.

The clang of weapons filled the air, rhythmic and endless. The echo of steel on steel began to sound like a drumbeat, too loud, too steady. The afternoon light reflected off armor until it blurred into one blinding field of brightness. Her actions looped like a broken record as she commanded and corrected, on repeat. The world around her started to feel thin and distant. The clang of metal turned dull in her ears, thudding faintly instead of ringing. Faces blurred at the edges.

Adora clenched her hands into fists and pushed her nails into her palms, feeling tiny bursts of pain, sharp and grounding. For a moment, it seemed to help, but then her focus slipped again. She continued to move and command automatically even while her mind drifted as stress forced dissociation.

The guards dispersed for the day. She had dismissed them without even noticing. She walked through Bright Moon castle in a daze as she headed back to her family suite. Her fingers trailed against the wall, cool stone grounding her for just a second before even that sensation seemed to dull.

Adora opened the door to a warm and dynamic scene. Rosra ran by with a stuffed animal held up high in her arms, her high-pitched laughter cutting through the air. Catra was at the table, plating stew and bread and helping Finn with an assignment. Cole was finishing setting the table with the clanks and clangs of

haphazardly set down silverware and cups. To Adora, it somehow all felt like it was happening from afar, her mind still adrift.

Catra greeted her with a fond smile, “Hey you, glad you’re here now. We were about to start without you.”

Adora forced a smile she couldn’t feel at all and said, “Looks great, thanks.”

When Catra laughed at something one of the kids said, Adora joined in automatically, but the sound was hollow and disconnected, as if it came from someone else.

She helped clear the table with slow movements. When Catra’s hand brushed hers, she startled and then flashed a strained smile. She caught Catra’s eyes for a moment and quickly looked away before the worry there could sink in.

“Mama, look! I made a sword out of blocks!” Rosra called out, breaking through her haze.

Adora turned, forcing brightness, “Wow! That’s just like mine.” Her tone was cheerful even as her eyes remained unfocused and her mind drifted, no matter how she tried to force herself to attend.

She looked around the room, seeing a toy she could mend and a rumpled blanket she should fold, but somehow these small tasks seemed impossible at the moment. She felt a desperation to fix things, and yet she couldn’t seem to get herself to cut through the fog enough to do anything that wasn’t essential.

Evening settled in. The warm glow of lamplight was soft on the walls. It was the kind of light that usually felt like home. Adora and Catra herded the kids off to bed together.

Adora leaned down and kissed each forehead, murmuring, “Goodnight, sleep well.”

Small arms wrapped around her neck, clinging tight. The warmth should’ve melted her. Instead, it hit her like a stab of guilt. She

loved her children so fiercely it hurt, but still she couldn't seem to be what they needed, no matter how hard she tried. They trusted her so much, and she was just letting them down. Despite the desperate desire in her heart to fix herself, the weight of everything still pressed on her so heavily.

Adora walked slowly into her bedroom. She felt both utterly drained and yet restless, like she couldn't stop thinking long enough to rest.

Catra watched her from the doorway, eyes searching, and Adora matched her gaze with wide, pleading eyes of her own.

"I'm trying so hard, Catra. I keep telling myself I'll do better, that I'll be the person you and the kids deserve, and then I just… I can't." Adora's voice was small and trembling as she tried to explain something even she couldn't fully understand. "I keep slipping."

Catra quickly closed the distance between them and brushed back a few pieces of Adora's hair from her face tenderly. "You don't have to do anything," Catra said with soft sincerity. "You're already everything we need."

Adora looked down, her voice even softer, "But I don't feel like it. I feel like I'm failing all the time, and I don't even know why."

Catra cupped Adora's face and tilted it back toward her. "You're not failing. You're just tired." She kissed her lightly on the forehead. "Just breathe. Let me hold you."

Catra opened her arms for Adora, who leaned fully into the embrace. She pressed her face into the hollow between Catra's shoulder and neck. Catra felt so warm and solid and steady. Adora breathed her in with desperation, her smell achingly familiar, subtly sweet and a bit musky. Adora felt the scratch of claws tracing along her back, and Catra's tail looped around Adora's wrist with a gentle pressure. Both actions grounded her. For a moment, Adora felt safe and perfectly content, but then

everything started to unravel again as if her mind could barely allow itself even a minute of peace.

Adora was showing up. She was more than showing up; she was pushing, trying with everything in her, and yet it still didn't seem to be enough. She was not enough. Not enough for her kids, her guards, or for Etheria. She could save the universe, but not hold herself together.

Catra's embrace tightened, and Adora leaned heavier into it, eyes closing. For now, she let herself stay there, even if the ache didn't fade.

They climbed into bed, the light flickering out as the room filled with moonlight and shadows. Catra drifted to sleep easily, her breathing steady and calm. Adora lay still, staring up at the ceiling. The low whistle of the wind slipped through the window cracks, a faint, haunting sound that carried her restless thoughts with it.

She turned on her side, watching Catra sleep for a moment, and then slowly Adora sat up. Streaks of moonlight lit up her face, and her eyes were bright with a new sense of determination, a desperate sort of clarity. Inside her, the pulse of something fierce and familiar began to stir again. If she couldn't fix it, she would fight it.

She'd beaten worse things than shadows before. She could do it again. From somewhere deep inside, the part of her that had always risen when everything else fell apart began to awaken.

Chapter 5

In the darkest part of the night, Adora silently slipped away from Bright Moon castle. The hallways were quiet except for the soft echo of her boots on the polished floor, the sound swallowed by the stillness of the corridor. With a soft grunt of effort, she pushed open the postern gate and stepped from the warmth of the castle into the cool late-night air. Its chill hit her skin like a warning.

Adora headed out past the empty training yards to a clearing. It may have once been part of a garden, though now it was just a wide open space with flat, overgrown stones underfoot. It was far enough from the castle that even loud sounds wouldn’t carry back to disturb those asleep inside.

The night was lit only by a faint moon, low among the dark clouds. Mist curled up from the ground, cool against Adora’s boots. There was a faint rustle of wind in the nearby trees. The silence was thick and expectant, almost like Etheria was holding its breath.

Adora felt like she was on high alert, her senses attuned and on edge, her exhausted body running fully on her adrenaline-fueled need. She was determined now to face and vanquish the shadow that haunted her. She would fight it to fix it.

The air felt charged as Adora lifted her hand toward the sky, curling her fingers slightly as she summoned She-Ra from deep within herself. She felt a brief flicker of fear. What if She-Ra wouldn't come?

After a moment though, her magic answered her call, power clawing upward and through her in a surge of white-gold light that surrounded her as her form transformed into a gold-armored warrior. Her body felt fortified and enhanced. Her sword formed in her hand. It felt heavier than she remembered.

Adora called out into the night, “You wanted a fight? To finish the job? Fine, I’m here now.” Her voice cracked on the last word. She pushed away her uncertainty, leaning into her determination as she steeled herself. “I’m ready.”

Her voice hung on the wind, echoing faintly in the silence. The air thickened, heavy and cold. The mist that had only swirled at her boots now began to coil upward, tightening around her. The night felt too still, like a breath held, waiting to exhale.

For a heartbeat, Adora hoped all might stay quiet. A small part of her wanted the shadow not to appear, not to be real, to just be in her head. She knew though, that would not be the case.

The temperature dropped. Mist recoiled as Adora’s shadow solidified. It lifted upward from the ground, distorting as Shadow She-Ra materialized fully formed, standing before Adora once more.

Shadow She-Ra was her perfect mirror, but in dark shadow form. Her flowing hair was like a cascade of black fire compared to She-Ra’s own pale liquid gold. Her eyes blazed white-blue, and a soft backlit glow surrounded her as if the initial energy of transformation never quite faded away from Shadow She-Ra. Her sword hummed with dark energy, a low vibration that thrummed through the air.

A low, layered voice that echoed Adora’s own rang out against the silence in an odd and detached tone, “You summoned me. Do you think you can destroy who you are?”

Adora glared at the shadowy figure. “You’re not me,” she insisted fiercely.

“I’m everything you won’t look at, everything you try to hide away,” the shadow replied, eerily calm.

Adora didn’t want to hear any more of this. She didn't want to try to process it further. Her exhausted, adrenaline-fueled mind

couldn't really digest it fully anyway. She wasn't here to debate her shadow. She was determined now to fight.

Adora charged forward, and Shadow She-Ra mirrored her every movement. The impact of their swords sent up a shockwave. Light and darkness intermingled. The clash of their blades echoed around them like a burst of thunder.

Adora attacked fiercely. Every strike was desperate. Her sword's light cut through the dark mist in frenetic strokes. It was a blur of glowing gold.

At first, Adora's blows seemed to be causing Shadow She-Ra to stagger or flicker. It seemed that Adora might have the upper hand. She would destroy Shadow She-Ra as she intended.

Adrenaline continued to course through Adora, cutting off her awareness of her own bodily sensations. This pushed her own flares of pain at each strike against the shadow to the back of her mind. Though the more she struck Shadow She-Ra, the more she noticed the pain rebounding in her own aching ribs.

Sparks and embers of gold and black danced through the air, and stones cracked beneath their feet from wayward blows. Each strike tore through the mist, scattering ribbons of shadow and flares of gold that faded to ash. As their blades met, golden light splintered into shards and darkness bled like ink across the sky.

Adora continued to tell herself that she just needed to fight harder to win this. Though somewhere at the edge of her recognition, she felt her strength, her magic, beginning to flicker and destabilize.

"You can't fight what's inside you without tearing yourself apart." The cold version of her own voice echoed through her. "Every blow you land only deepens the wound within."

They parried strike after strike without a hit, as Adora began to succumb to exhaustion. Her heart raced. Her muscles trembled.

The light of her sword burned, desperate and uneven, like a star on the verge of collapse.

The voice rose once more from the shadow. “Etheria needs a reliable protector to stand in the light. If the darkness within you becomes too much, Etheria will bring forth another.”

The words hit Adora harder than the physical blows as she took in the full weight of their meaning. For a heartbeat, Adora forgot to breathe. Her chest felt tight. The idea that she was replaceable, that the magic might decide she wasn’t enough, ignited something wild and terrified inside of her. Her pulse thundered loudly in her ears. The golden glow of her sword trembled and flickered almost as if it doubted her right to hold it.

“No,” she rasped, her voice shaking. “I won’t let that happen.”

Adora drew forth every last fragment of strength, fury, and desperation into one motion and raised her sword to deliver a fearsome strike. Their swords collided in mid-air. Shadow She-Ra’s sword pierced through Adora’s blade. Shards of crystal exploded outward. Gold sparks scattered into the air. As their blades collided for the last time, the impact wasn’t sound, but light, pure and unbearable. The world inverted in a flare of gold and black so bright it left afterimages burned into the air. The noise seemed to drain from the world.

The impact of the blow hit into Adora. She felt a sudden disorientation and a ringing in her ears. The ground tilted. Adora collapsed to her knees on the stones. Her She-Ra magic flickered and sputtered like a flame in the wind. Her wounded sword was fading in and out of her hand. The acrid smell of scorched armor and stone overwhelmed her senses. Flashes of pain coursed through her body as her breath came ragged and shallow.

“No,” Adora whispered, and it came out as just a rasp of air.

Shadow She-Ra knelt before her and said quietly, almost gently, “You can’t win this battle, Adora, not by fighting me.”

Adora tried to rise but failed. She tried to force her transformation again. The magic just sparked out.

Shadow She-Ra's hand brushed her cheek, not cruelly but with an eerie tenderness. "You're already hurting yourself more than I ever could."

The shadow faded into the mist, leaving Adora alone and feeling shattered as she knelt against the broken stones of the cracked ground beneath her. It was dark and far too silent. The only sounds were her own uneven breathing and the racing heartbeat that echoed in her ears.

Adora tried to stand again, and pain flared through her body. Everything felt heavy and wrong, but she pushed through it and managed to rise to her feet. She staggered across the training yards and toward the castle, her body bruised and battered and her movements stiff. A bone-deep exhaustion threatened to overwhelm her now that the adrenaline had left. Each step felt heavier than the last. She was drenched in cold sweat and shivered in the pre-dawn air.

As she pulled open the heavy postern gate of the castle, Adora saw that the first daymoon had begun to rise, streaks of red starting to light up the sky. She limped inside and down the hall, her body throbbing with every pounding heartbeat. Adora pushed into her suite and fumbled toward her bedroom. She stumbled into the darkened room, the weight of her exertion pulling her down as she collapsed in a heap against the door.

She tried to summon She-Ra once more to heal herself further, but the magic flickered unstably. Her breath stuttered as she trembled and shook. She shifted in and out of forms, the magic sputtering as her damaged sword faded in and out in her hand, crackling with unstable magic. Her armor, when it shifted in, was scorched in places.

The noise and flickers of light had woken Catra, and Adora heard more than saw her wife stirring from the bed. A sharp intake of

breath cut through the air.

“Adora!” Catra called out frantically at the sight before her. She scrambled from the bed and dropped to her knees beside her, unfiltered fear widening the pupils of her mismatched eyes.

Adora stopped trying to hold onto her unstable magic, letting it fully fade, leaving her slumped and exhausted.

“What happened? Are you hurt?” Catra’s voice was raw with concern. Her claws retracted instinctively even as her hands hovered over Adora as though she was afraid touching her might do more damage. Her ears were flattened, her tail twitching with anxiety.

Adora couldn’t meet Catra’s eyes. Not when they were that wide, frightened in a way Adora hadn’t seen in years. Her instinct was to lie. She told herself it was to keep Catra from worrying even more.

She drew a ragged breath, her voice rougher than she’d like, “I’m okay. Just… pushed too hard while I was training. Lost control of my magic a bit.”

Catra touched her shoulder, and Adora flinched, more from guilt than pain.

“Adora, this seems like more than a training accident.” Catra’s voice was laced with tight worry and disbelief.

“It’s fine. I just need to rest.” Adora said softly, trying to get Catra to calm down. Adora forced a shaky smile.

Catra whispered, “You don’t have to do this alone, you know.”

“I’m not, you’re here,” Adora replied quietly, though her eyes were distant.

Adora didn’t feel able to say more right now. There was nothing left in her but exhaustion. She wanted to say she was sorry. She

wanted to say she was scared. The words wouldn't form. Her mind was hazy and unfocused. Her body was a blur of pain.

She stripped off her boots and jacket, her movements stiff and jerky, though she tried not to show it. A shiver ran through her as she inched herself up onto the bed. Her eyelids felt heavy and her limbs leaden. Magic still buzzed faintly in her bones.

From beyond the door came the soft stirrings of morning as small voices carried through the air. They both turned toward the sound.

“Adora, just sleep. I’ll get the kids ready for their lessons,” Catra assured her.

Catra looked like she wanted to stay as she hesitated at the doorway, tail twitching once and ears flicking toward Adora, before she slipped out to tend to the children. The sound of the door clicking shut left the room too quiet.

Adora sank into her pillow, exhaustion tugging at her. She tried to tell herself she’d be able to fight the shadow better next time. That she’d find a way to win. Though as sleep dragged her under, she accepted the truth. This wasn't a battle to be won by fighting. She was only fighting herself.



Chapter 6

Blinking groggily, Adora stirred at the sound of nearby movement. She heard the soft pad of Catra's feet and the rustle of fabric as her wife pulled on her blouse and readied herself for work. Soft morning light spilled into their room and across the floor, warm and golden. It felt too bright.

Adora started to push herself up from the heavy tangle of blankets. Before she had even sat up fully, Catra appeared at her side, pressing a gentle hand to her shoulder. She guided Adora back against her pillow once more.

Catra gave her a small, worried smile, her dual-colored eyes filled with concern, as she said, "Adora, you should stay in bed. I'll let Commander Minna know you need the morning off."

Adora protested weakly, "No, I should-"

Catra cut her off, "You should rest. You need to sleep more." Her tone was firm, though her mismatched eyes showed a mix of warmth and worry. Her hand lingered on Adora's shoulder.

Adora didn't want to shirk her responsibilities, but her body still felt far too heavy, and her eyelids were definitely dragging. She'd be hard-pressed to make it through her work if she pushed right now. So she nodded and sank further into her pillow. Though some part of her knew even rest wouldn't fully reach the piece of her deep inside that truly ached.

Catra brushed a few pieces of Adora's hair back behind her ear and pressed a kiss to her temple. Catra looked conflicted, like she wanted to say something more, but she knew Adora needed rest right now more than anything else. So with one last fleeting look, she said, "I love you, Adora. Just sleep now."

Adora, already drifting off, mumbled, "Love you too," before sleep fully claimed her once more.

Adora slept hard and only awoke hours later. She pushed up and took stock of herself. She felt a lot better than when she had dragged herself into the room hours earlier. The heaviness of exhaustion had passed, and though there was still a dull ache throughout her body and some tenderness in her ribs, the pain no longer flared.

She swung her feet over the side of the bed and found she was able to stand fairly easily, though her movements still had some lingering stiffness. Adora moved about the room, readying herself for her day. She then left the bedroom for the kitchen.

Light poured into the suite from the large arched windows that lined the outer wall. Bright beams scattered across the cluttered countertop and table. Adora pulled together some simple food and began to eat. Melog approached and pressed against her leg gently, and Adora gave it an absent-minded pat.

As soon as she was still, her thoughts quickly began to circle back to the events of the past night. She had tried to vanquish the shadow, but failed. She swallowed hard at that disconcerting fact. Her hand trembled a bit at her side. She couldn't seem to fix herself or fight off this issue, so what was she to do next?

And then, there were the shadow’s words. If her darkness became too much, Etheria would try to replace her? Is that what the shadow was ultimately here to do?

Adora’s heart began to race at these thoughts. She felt fear gripping her and panic starting to build. Her shoulders tensed.

Adora forced herself to breathe deeply and drive back the rising tide of her emotions. “You’re fine. You’re fine,” she muttered to herself.

She didn't know what she needed to do next. For now, all she could really do was try to just take the best step forward. She’d just take things one moment at a time and not let her thoughts get ahead of her.

Rising from the table, Adora steeled herself with a calming breath in through her nose. She was strong. She could do this. Though she still questioned what exactly this even meant right now. She pushed away those uncertainties and left her quarters.

Adora walked the familiar, crystal-lit halls of Bright Moon and headed straight for the training yards. For now, she would just focus on helping her guards. Hopefully, she could do at least that much.

The crisp grass crunched beneath her feet as she stepped out into the afternoon brightness. It felt harsh to her tired eyes. The yards were fairly empty as most guards were still having lunch. Adora busied herself with gathering the needed armor and weapons for the standard afternoon activities.

Her guards arrived back at the yard, and Adora smoothly directed them through their weapons rotation. The clangs of metal-on-metal were sharp in her ears. Near the end of the day, the sounds of a commotion nearby rose up from the edge of the yard.

A junior guard had accidentally triggered a defensive ward at the edge of the Bright Moon grounds. The guard now hung in the air. He was suspended several feet above the ground with tendrils of glowing energy wrapped around his limbs.

Adora rushed over to help. Other senior commanders gathered as well, and Adora could see others hurrying out from the castle, too. She caught a glimpse of Glimmer and Bow teleporting nearby.

Adora raised her hand to summon her magic from within. The light surged but sputtered, flickering unevenly. Her wounded sword phased in and out of her hand. Her golden glow darkened deeply for a moment and then faded out completely.

Adora’s chest seized. The hum of the ward, the brightness of the light, the noises of the gathering crowd, all seemed to intensify and tighten around her. Her focus faded. She heard snippets of

buzzing concern: “Did her magic flicker out? Is everything okay? Where’s She-Ra?”

Then, the guard hanging in the ward whimpered, and Adora forced herself to move. Her legs were more unsteady than she would have liked. Still, she quickly picked up a discarded fighting staff and stepped toward the dangling guard.

“Stay still. I’ve got you.” She willed herself to sound calm, to not let her rising panic show.

Using the staff as a lever, she forced the ward’s tendrils apart with just her standard strength, her still battered ribs aching from the effort. Slowly, inch by inch, the tendrils unraveled, and she pulled the guard free and lowered him toward the ground. He was shaken but unharmed.

The tense atmosphere of the yard gave way to relieved chatter. The end-of-rotation cleanup activities resumed. The training yards were filled with familiar rhythms once more.

Adora stood panting, and her stomach churned. She hadn’t been able to be She-Ra. Her magic had faltered.

“Adora, that didn’t look right,” she heard Glimmer say as the Queen approached with Bow at her side. She glanced up to see their furrowed brows and the surprise in their expressions.

“It’s fine. It’s nothing. I… I just lost focus,” Adora stammered. She so wanted to believe what she was saying was true.

“Adora,” Bow started softly as he stepped toward her, “You don't have to pretend it's fine.”

“You haven't lost She-Ra like that in years,” Glimmer pushed.

“Well, I guess I have now,” Adora replied softly, defeatedly. Her energy and will seemed to have drained right out of her. She turned and walked away before they could say more. A bird

startled into flight at her sudden motion. She just couldn't face this right now.

As she strode quickly back across the yard, her thoughts spun with this latest failure. Could she not be She-Ra because the shadow had damaged her magic? Was her She-Ra magic turning on her?

Her heart began to pound, and her shoulders tensed as she felt herself slipping into panic. Adora felt far too on edge, like she couldn’t quite remember anymore how to be calm. The sensation intensified until her mind began to drift into dissociation.

Everything began to feel distant, muffled, and dim. It was like she was drifting through a dream of herself. She walked the halls of Bright Moon, but they felt off and wrong, more dull than usual. She caught a glimpse of her reflection and barely recognized herself. She felt a vague, lingering soreness in her muscles.

Adora entered her family suite and sank into a seat at the table, hands slack in her lap. She tried to think of what she should do next, but her thoughts seemed to dissolve partly through forming. Melog padded over and pressed against her leg, and Adora barely even noticed the sensation.

The quiet pressed in around her, and she welcomed it. She stared aimlessly, just letting numbness surround her. Maybe if she stayed still enough, she could keep herself from cracking apart any further.

The sound of chatter and footsteps outside the door alerted Adora that her children were home, pulling her halfway back to reality. The door burst open, and they rushed inside, tossing their satchels haphazardly and starting up on activities. Finn settled on the couch with a book, Cole continued a partially completed puzzle, and Rosra started on a drawing with her crayons while she hummed to herself. Melog wandered amongst them.

Adora watched as if in slow motion. The sight should have warmed her, but all she felt was a faint echo of how she remembered it should feel. It was like a hollow space where her emotions were meant to reside.

The door soon opened again, and Catra entered with a stack of hot platters. Her voice rang out cheerful and easy, "Dinner delivery coming through."

Catra's cheer set Adora on edge, and she flinched slightly at the sound.

Catra gave Finn's shoulder a soft squeeze, ruffled Cole's ginger hair, and kissed the top of Rosra's head as she moved from the doorway, through the room and towards the table. Her eyes, though, kept darting toward Adora as if assessing her state, a mix of love and concern mingling in her mismatched gaze. Her tail flicked each time.

As she reached the table, Catra gave Adora a quick kiss on the cheek as she set down the platters. Adora saw Catra's smile falter, the worry flickering in her dual-colored eyes.

"Hey," Catra said softly. "How are you?"

"I'm fine," Adora replied flatly, her eyes distant.

Catra hesitated, like she was uncertain how to respond, before just saying, "Okay, let me know if you need anything."

Adora only nodded back as she reached for the platters and automatically began to portion out servings to the kids. She handed them out without more than a detached, "Here."

She ate some of the food herself, though she found she could barely taste it. Her mind stayed distant, unable to focus on any of what was happening around her. She was listless, her posture slumped. The chatter around her blurred into a low hum. Her mind floated elsewhere.

After dinner, the children continued with their earlier activities and soon Rosra called out warmly, waving her picture before her, “Look, it’s mama saving everyone as She-Ra.”

Adora’s throat tightened, those words cutting through her fog. She stared at the waxy crayon drawing on the paper, She-Ra with flowing yellow hair and a big golden sword. It was a version of herself that felt impossibly far away. Her eyes burned, and she felt like a fraud.

Catra’s voice came from somewhere behind her, asking something about bedtime routines.

“I-I don’t know. You decide,” Adora answered, unable to focus on the ask.

Soon, kids were tucked in bed, and as Adora sank back down at the table, she couldn't even be sure if she had kissed them goodnight. Her chest, her head, they just felt empty.

Catra stood across from Adora, clearing up dishes. The room was silent except for the soft clink of the dishware and the low hum of the crystal lights. Catra’s tail flicked uneasily.

After a moment, Catra’s voice broke the quiet, soft with concern. “Are you sure you’re okay?”

“Yeah… yeah, I’m fine,” Adora replied, the words flat.

Catra stepped closer, bracing a hand against the tabletop. “I don't know, Adora,” Catra replied, her tone edged with increasing worry. “You keep saying that like it means something.”

That broke through a bit, and Adora replied with a soft desperation, “It has to mean something.”

Adora felt so far adrift now. She really needed something to grasp onto. She needed to believe that she could still be fine. She needed to feel like there was still some chance that she wasn't irreparably broken.

Her She-Ra magic had turned on her, and Etheria had sent a shadow to destroy her. The truth pressed in too close. That certainly didn't sound fine.

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> Just letting everyone know that I have added the Self-Destruction, Suicidal Thoughts, and Psychological Trauma tags due to content in the next few chapters.

The Whispering Woods were filled with fog, thick and murky and pressing in all around her. It blurred the trees and made every sound feel muted and muffled. Even the echoes of birdsong seemed odd and hollow amidst the haze.

Everything was damp, and Adora's boots sank deeply into the mossy ground as drifts of fog shifted and curled tightly around her legs. Diffused light filtered through the canopy of trees in fractured beams, her own flickering glow distorting it further.

Her magic resisted her control, recoiling every time she reached for it. Trying to keep her She-Ra form was like trying to hold a bolt of lightning in place. It faltered mid-shift, her armor half-formed, her light not quite fully taking shape. Her golden glow collapsed into dimming sparks. The air shivered with static.

Adora winced as with each attempt, the power surged and burned through her veins. Each wave of magic felt like a pressure against her very bones. It twisted within her, volatile and raw. Her sword faded in and out of her hand, its blade half-healed but still missing small shards. Each pulse was a shift of weight that unbalanced her and made her stagger. Her magic faltered. It stuttered. It shuddered against her will.

Adora didn't know how many hours she'd been in these Woods, as time seemed to blur with the repetition of her efforts. Each attempt at transformation bled into the next until time felt as warped as the distorted light seeping through the fog. Still, she pushed again and again, willing stability to come. Each attempt drained her a little bit more. Her body was taxed by the constant

strain. She felt a continuous ringing in her ears and a slight tremor in her muscles.

Alongside her failing light and flickering magic, her thoughts churned, leaving her no peace. She had truly ruined everything in her life. She was eroding and destroying everything she had ever loved, unable to fix it or feel it like she once had before. She couldn't quite grasp how this slow descent into unravelling had started, but now she felt powerless to stop it. She didn't feel like anything at this point could actually change things or help her anymore. She was afraid that she was irreparably broken, well beyond fixing. How had she let things go this far? It felt like every hour, she was slipping further and further away from herself. Her thoughts were dense, suffocating, and impossible to escape.

This dark cloud of thoughts hung over her so thickly that the faint echo of hooves didn't even register at first. They were rhythmic, yet oddly distant even as they approached, muffled by the fog. The sound seemed almost unreal.

“Adora?” Swift Wind called out, his voice a mix of care and unease. His orange mane emerged unexpectedly through the haze.

The sudden voice cut through her thoughts like a sharp crack of thunder. Adora turned, startled, not having even registered his approach. Her body reacted before her mind could even think. Instinct and panic collided, and her power reacted wildly.

A burst of her magic flared out of her control. A laser-sharp beam of prismatic light shot from her mangled, flickering sword and struck against the ground, mere feet from the alicorn. It left a dark scorch mark in its wake. Golden flickers of light suspended in the fog, distorting and refracting.

“Whoa, Adora! It’s me!” Swift Wind reared back, wings outstretched instinctively. His eyes went wide with shock.

She gasped and stuttered out, “I… Swift Wind, I didn't...” Adora’s words broke off, as shame flooded through the adrenaline. Her hands trembled. Magic pulsed through her veins like the aftershocks of a quake.

After a moment, Swift Wind spoke softly, “Your magic doesn't feel like you. It’s angry… It’s like it's fighting itself.”

Adora’s throat tightened. “I’m sorry. I can't seem to control it right now.” Her voice cracked on the last few words.

Swift Wind looked distressed as he asked, “Should I get some kind of help?”

Adora’s blue eyes widened as she made a desperate plea, “No. Please don't. I’m out here to fix this. I need to do this alone.” Her eyes darted to the ground as she continued more softly, almost reluctantly, “But you’d better go. It's not stable yet, and I don't want you to get hurt.”

Swift Wind nodded, and with a last hesitant look, retreated. The steady beat of his hooves was quickly swallowed by the fog. The silence that followed felt emptier than Adora could bear.

Collapsing to her knees, the fluttering light surrounding her fully sputtered out. Adora felt like more of a failure than ever. Her magic now seemed truly uncontrollable and dangerous. She was afraid she would hurt where she was supposed to protect. She wrapped her arms tightly around her torso, as if to physically hold herself together.

The fog, almost as if it sensed her increased distress, thickened around her. It curled low and tight, and the air hummed. Trees seemed to lean in ever closer. Her shadow elongated and distorted. It stretched impossibly long across the moss-covered ground, and then peeled off like oil on water and began to rise. Shadow She-Ra stepped out of the mist. Her eyes gleamed faintly through the haze.

Adora’s chest clenched, and her breath caught. “No…” she whispered, but didn't rise. Her body felt weighed down and pinned to the ground. She was too emotionally exhausted, too distraught. Even her heartbeat felt slow and muted by despair.

“You’re falling into darkness, Adora,” Shadow She-Ra said in an eerie, detached echo of Adora’s own voice. It reverberated through her mind. “You can feel it, can't you? Part of you is slipping away.”

The words hit Adora like the surge of a storm. They battered at the edges of her mind, threatening to unmake her. Adora tried to deny them, but her reply died on her tongue as her voice sputtered out just like her magic. She couldn't even count on her own voice anymore. It had abandoned her and left her without control.

The calm, distant tone of the shadow continued on, soft and slow like a wave cresting through her consciousness. “You’re not protecting them by staying away. You’re just disappearing. You can’t fix what you won’t face.”

The words lingered in the air, sinking deeply before fading to nothing as Adora’s breath hitched and she covered her face with both hands. Her eyes burned, and tears streaked down her face. Her shoulders trembled with every shaky inhale.

When she finally looked up, the shadow was gone. Adora was left in the silence of the Woods with just the sounds of her ragged breathing and the echoes of her sobs. The ever-present fog was indifferent to her pain.

The words “You’re just disappearing,” echoed through her mind.

Adora clenched her jaw. “I’m not,” she said softly, the words barely audible. She wished she believed them. She pressed a hand to her chest as if she could keep herself from withering away.

The light faded to dusk, then deepened into evening. Eventually, Adora pushed herself up off the ground with trembling arms, the moss slick beneath her feet. The Woods blurred in the darkness and haze, trees melting into silhouettes. Adora tried to steady her uneven breathing as she trudged back toward Bright Moon castle. The walk was long and quiet, shrouded in thick fog. Her boots kept sinking down into the mud, and every step felt heavy.

The fog thinned as she neared the edge of the Woods, but it didn't fully lift. It continued to cling to her boots. She could see Bright Moon’s gleaming white towers through the mist, distant and almost unreal, growing as she approached.

The castle’s light felt too bright after the dimness of the Woods, and Adora squinted in its glare. The air was warm, but it did little to relieve the chill settled deep in her bones. She heard the sound of voices muffled behind doors.

Passing a tall window in the hall, she caught her reflection and stopped. Mud streaked her clothing, and her hair was damp and disheveled. Her eyes were red-rimmed, and tear tracks streaked through the grime on her cheeks. She was a wreck.

Adora pushed through the door to her suite, stepping into the quiet of the softly lit kitchen. Catra sat leafing through reports at the table. The kids were already asleep, their soft breathing drifting from the next room.

Catra looked up. Her tail flicked once, then stilled as she rose from her chair. The gleam of the lamplight caught in her mismatched eyes. They were soft but also sharp with worry.

Adora froze in the doorway, unsure what to say or do. Her throat felt too tight to speak. Her body seemed caught between stepping forward and turning away. Catra’s presence felt like warmth and ache all at once.

“Where were you?” Catra asked softly, not accusing, just wide-eyed with concern as she stepped closer.

Adora mumbled, “Just training.” Her eyes were fixed on the floor. Catra’s concern should have made her feel cared for and safe, but instead, it twisted her stomach with guilt.

“You’ve been gone all day. You look…” Catra’s voice trailed off, but Adora could tell something like broken was what she was thinking.

Adora’s chest tightened. “I just needed to be alone. I didn't want to…” she faltered, voice breaking, “…to make things worse for everyone.” She didn’t want to be a burden. She was supposed to be the strong one.

Catra reached for her hand, “You don't make things worse, Adora.”

Adora flinched back, the motion small but sharp. She was afraid of herself, afraid of spreading her own darkness to Catra. Her voice was barely audible, “Maybe I do. Maybe you shouldn't…”

Catra’s expression crumpled. Her tail lowered, and her ears drooped. For a moment, her hand just hung awkwardly in the air between them, hovering inches from Adora, hesitant and reaching. Then, she stepped forward and pulled Adora into her arms.

“I love you,” she murmured into Adora’s shoulder as she squeezed her close. “That doesn't stop even if you’re falling apart.”

Adora stiffened, her breath catching. “Maybe it should,” she whispered so small that Catra barely heard it.

Catra just held her tighter. The quiet of the night was filled now only by Adora’s uneven breathing. Catra’s warmth surrounded her, steady and sure, but Adora still felt cold, as if the light inside her had already slipped beyond reach. She had left the fog of the Woods, but she still felt stuck in the fog of her own mind.

Chapter 8

Stretched peacefully beside her, Catra was deep asleep, her breathing rhythmic, her tail curled loosely over Adora’s arm. Adora, however, lay wide awake in the silence. Though she had forced her breathing to mimic the slowed cadence of sleep for Catra’s sake, she was actually far from peace.

Everything felt eerily still around her. It was the kind of quiet that felt wrong. It was as if the whole of Etheria was holding its breath, just waiting for her to crack. Her heartbeats echoed loudly in her ears. Guilt churned like acid, burning through her stomach.

From the next room came the soft creak of a bed as one of the kids shifted in sleep, just one thin wall away. Catra’s warmth against her side should have grounded her, but it only deepened the feeling of wrongness. Adora didn't deserve to be this close to someone so steady.

The crumpled expression and drooped ears from when Adora had flinched earlier flickered suddenly through her mind. Heat rose in her throat. Her chest tightened.

Her pulse began to quicken in the hollow of her throat like the rev-up of a skiff engine. Each beat pounded against her ribs. Adora pressed her hand to her chest as if the pressure could muffle the thud. It didn't help. It only grew tighter with every breath. Her skin was sweat-damp through the thin fabric of her sleep shirt.

A small spark ignited from the pad of her index finger. It clung, sharp and insistent. Another flickered off of her thumb. Light flooded unbidden across all of her fingertips. The glow of magic wasn't the usual warm, soft gold anymore, but a harsh, cool white.

It wasn't power coursing and controlled, but the building of unasked-for pressure. It stretched against her skin until she could

feel her pulse beating in her fingernails. Adora rushed to hide her hands beneath the blanket, trying to smother out the light.

Catra’s tail twitched once against her arm, just a reflex in sleep. Still, that tiny motion felt like an accusation. Adora was terrified that she wouldn't be able to control her magic.

Her breath hitched. The room hadn't changed temperature, yet sweat beaded along her hairline. Adora tasted a bitterness in her mouth, the flavor of every failure and every promise she couldn't keep.

Panic stopped being a sensation and became a texture, suffocating and wrapping tightly around her lungs. She worried that if she opened her mouth, light would stream out instead of air. If she moved, the sparks might jump onto Catra, onto the sheets, onto the small, defenseless bodies sleeping just one wall away.

The fear curdled into shame. She was a terrible wife and mother. She was a failure to everyone. She couldn't protect anyone. She was just a burden.

Silver moonlight filtered through the curtains and streaked the room with shadows that stretched dark and looming across the floor. The night felt too thin. Faint sounds filtered in from beyond the window.

The edges of the room blurred, the outlines softening until shadows started to feel like they were closing in on her. The movements were too deliberate to be a trick of the eye. They seemed too still, too close. The air thickened, and noises became muffled. The silence of the room intensified like all of its sound had been suddenly swallowed. The air in the room seemed to drop a few degrees and hum forebodingly.

A shiver ran through her, and Adora sat bolt upright in bed. Her shadow stretched across the floor at her motion. It rippled like ink spilled across water. Then it distorted and grew. It detached from

the floor and stood before her once more solidified, as the full form of Shadow She-Ra emerged.

“No. Not here.” Adora’s words were barely audible, a taut whisper of distress.

A voice so like her own, but detached, calm, and eerily empty, echoed in her ears. “You called me here. Every dark, self-loathing thought you’ve had, summoned me. I’m what you’ve made of yourself.” Shadow She-Ra’s eyes glowed chillingly.

Adora stumbled from the bed, trembling. She stood on shaky legs. The faint light from her hands illuminated her haunted face. Shadow She-Ra mirrored her, and so with each step forward, they both moved closer towards one another.

“Please stop. Y-You don't get to be here.” Adora pleaded softly, her voice small and shaking.

Shadow She-Ra tilted her head, curious, a gesture that was almost tender and empathetic. The calm voice of the shadow was laced with cruel honesty as it continued, “It’s not so easy to fix what you’ve broken. You avoid your children and flinch from your own wife now. Every wound you’ve tried to bury. Every fear you’ve denied. That’s me. You’re just hiding from it in the dark.”

Adora fell to her knees and staggered back into the corner of the room. Shadow She-Ra followed. She knelt before her, looming over her.

The shadow’s words were calm yet coldly cruel. “Your instability is overtaking you. You are unravelling completely. You are no longer a hero who can stand in the light.”

Adora couldn't take this anymore. She was being haunted by this shadow. Tortured by it. She felt overwhelmed by its constant, malicious presence and its cutting words.

Shadow She-Ra, as if sensing her thoughts, leaned ever closer, embracing her and merging into her. It felt like a whisper of

coldness, and a shiver ran through Adora like a tremor.

The room dimmed, moonlight fading unnaturally. Adora couldn't breathe. She couldn't think anymore. She just needed the shadow gone.

Adora braced herself against the wall. Her eyes glowed blue-white as she summoned her magic. Her whole body pulsed with energy. The air around her hummed and buzzed with power. Pressure built in her ears like a storm about to break.

Flashes filled her mind with the faces and voices of everyone she loved and yet managed to hurt and disappoint. A glass of water tipped and droplets suspended in the air as Adora's sharp, "You never mean to…" rang louder in her head than the clang of a sword. In each hanging globule of water, she saw the reflection of Cole's golden eyes widened in shock and then squinted closed in pain.

Then Ryn's foot crossed over the chalk line into the wrong unit. The white line was smudged by his heel. The tendrils of the ward tightened around another young guard's boot in her seconds of failure to transform, and his wince pierced the air.

Each flash struck harder than the last. The boundaries between memory and self thinning until she couldn't tell if she was watching the past or reliving her failures in the present. Catra's hand curled into a fist in mid-air, the word "bailing" echoing angrily.

The flashes cut like a blade of guilt pressing deeper and deeper into her heart. Each image layered on the last, stacking weight until the inside of her skull felt scraped raw.

It was too much. She just wanted silence. All of this noise needed to stop.

"Get out of me," she cried softly, desperately. She clutched at her chest, the fabric of her sleep shirt knotting in her hands. She

willed herself to burn out the shadow, the darkness within her, to purge it from herself.

She raised her right hand, fingers flared outward, and the transformation surge ignited. Instead of warm, radiant light rising up to surround her, it convulsed. Light collapsed inward. Golden sparks twisted into black fissures across her skin.

The shadow laughed, a horrible, mirrored sound that came from inside her own throat.

"I… I need to destroy you." Adora choked out as she forced more light and power to surge through herself.

Light and darkness erupted chaotically. Every wave of golden glow met with a violent crush of darkness. Adora felt the magic warring against itself, tearing at her from the inside. Heat, pressure, and pain built to a crescendo. Her skin was too tight to contain the magic inside her. Every nerve screamed. It was too much, too bright, too alive. Her bones vibrated. Light fractured into shards like glass caught in mid-shatter, and darkness laced through it like veins of ink.

For a moment, everything went silent. Then the world broke apart. The storming magic backfired violently, throwing Adora across the room. A photo frame fell from the wall and smashed to the floor. Sound dropped out of the room in a shockwave. A sudden burst of heat surged through the air. Her hair was singed, and she was surrounded by stuttering light, her body seizing with each rippled glow. There was a metallic taste on her tongue. Her heartbeat seemed to falter and loop out of sync with itself.

From what felt like too afar for the small space of their bedroom, Adora heard Catra jolt awake with a sudden gasp.

"Adora? Adora! Stop! What did you do?" Fear and panic rose in Catra's voice. She slid from the bed and was beside Adora in a second, gripping her shoulders. Catra let out a low hiss as a wayward spark burned into her sleeve.

“I… I have to get it out,” Adora stammered as she continued to force her magic, curling in on herself. Her breath came in short, ragged gasps, each inhale laced with pain.

“You’re hurting yourself! Look at me. Please! Just look at me!” Catra’s words were desperate. Her thumb brushed gently along the burn marks that tracked across Adora’s arms. “Talk to me! You have to tell me what’s happening. Don't do this alone!”

“It… It’s inside me. I… I can't make it stop,” Adora struggled to speak. Her eyes flicked up. They were unfocused, pupils blown wide. Waves of prismatic light pulsed all around her. Adora’s every nerve screamed, her magic too much to bear.

“You’re burning yourself apart!” Catra admonished, her voice cracking between anger and fear.

The sound was a warm thread that cut through the cold static of Adora’s mind. Catra pulled Adora fiercely into her arms, careful not to press too hard against the burns.

Adora whispered, “I can’t fix what’s broken in me.”

Tears streamed down her face as sobs overtook her. She had stopped pulling forth her power, but aftershocks of it still pulsed through her body. She felt her wife’s arms circled around her, holding her tight, even as Catra’s whole body shook, matching her own trembling. Catra’s grip anchored her, but Adora still felt like she was slipping away, light fading into darkness.

Adora felt dizzy and weak. Her eyelids were heavy, and she was barely able to keep them open anymore. Her breathing was erratic, sweat and tears mixing in streaks down her face.

“Just hold on. Please, baby, please,” Catra begged softly, frantically.

“I… I just n-needed it g-gone,” Adora’s voice was barely a breath, the words stuttering as she struggled to stay conscious. Her body was starting to go limp. The last sparks of her magic had faded.

“Please, Adora. Don’t leave me. Not like this,” Catra pleaded and demanded, her pitch rising. A sound broke from her, something between a snarl and a sob. “Please, please, please…” Catra whispered the word over and over until her voice broke.

As Adora faded in and out of consciousness, she could hear snippets of whispered comforts and promises from Catra. The words were a soft, steady stream stating that Adora wasn’t alone, that she would get through this, that she would be okay. Adora could no longer tell if Catra’s voice was real or just the echo of past promises she had never deserved.

Adora let her eyes roll back and darkness close in around her. Then nothing, but the return of a too heavy silence. The air still vibrated like even the magic itself was afraid of what had just transpired.

Chapter 9

Morning came slow and gray. The pale light seeped in from the windows in thin, hesitant streaks that illuminated the room in a colorless wash that made everything feel distant and unreal. It was the kind of brightness that didn’t warm but only revealed. It was muted but still felt too sharp as it hit the barely open slits of Adora’s burning, gritty eyes.

The air itself felt thick in the aftermath of the night. An acrid, scorched scent still clung from the magic she had tried to purge. Every breath of it dragged against her lungs. The silence pressed close around her, too still, too taut. Even the soft, ever-present background hum of Bright Moon castle seemed heavy now on her bones. A faint pressure filled her ears, like the air hadn’t settled since the explosion of magic.

Her body didn’t feel like her own. Her skin felt too tight, as though she didn't quite fit inside it anymore. Every muscle ached, her limbs burdened with the pain of overwrought magic. The blanket across her chest felt suffocatingly heavy, its simple weight suddenly too much to bear. She couldn’t even seem to muster the strength to move it. She realized her limbs still trembled faintly.

Adora drew in a shallow breath, and even that small motion was pained. There was an emptiness inside her, a hollow where something vital had been carved away. Her magic, her strength, her certainty, each felt stripped from her, burned away in the violent unmaking of the night before. What was left was emptiness and the dull detachment of surviving something too harsh to fathom.

She lay on her side in the bed, numb in the half-light of dawn, eyes fully open now but still unfocused. The gray morning stretched seemingly endless before her. Sensory dissonance tugged at her as nothing in the room matched the deficiency within her. The bedroom was quiet and calm, but her body felt wrong. Her thoughts drifted, slow and distant.

A faint shift beside her broke the stillness. Catra stirred, her tail brushing against Adora's hip. Her breath grazed Adora's shoulder.

"Hey," Catra murmured, soft and raspy, "Are you awake, Adora? Are you okay?" Her voice was low and lingering with worry. Catra brushed hair back from Adora's face.

Adora didn't answer. She couldn't. Her throat felt closed. She just stared past the far wall, her breath shallow. Catra was pressed against her, but Adora couldn't even really feel her.

The bed dipped as Catra propped herself up on an elbow. Her voice softened even further, her concern deepening into compassion. "You're safe. It's over." Her mismatched eyes were red-rimmed and tender. Her gentle fingers trailed along the side of Adora's face.

It was meant to soothe, but to Adora it felt too close, too kind. Adora's gaze drifted past her and fixed on the washed-out ceiling. She didn't deserve the gentleness in Catra's voice and touch. Not after this. Not when she had tried to break herself apart. Not when she had dragged the corruption deeper instead of purging it. Her chest tightened.

Her throat felt dry as she finally forced words out. "It's not over," she whispered. "I made it worse."

Catra's tail flicked once, sounding quietly across the sheets. "Worse how?"

Adora didn't look at Catra. She couldn't bear it. Catra didn't see it yet. She didn't see how, despite her every effort, Adora was constantly making everything around her worse.

Catra's thumb traced along her arm in soft circles. The tender gesture set Adora on edge. Her gaze drifted slowly to the far corner of the room where shadows lingered along the bedroom floor. One seemed to stretch unnaturally, dark and lengthening.

Adora’s breath hitched. The silence loomed. A weightless feeling of dread spread like the whisper of a breeze as it brushed across her skin. Her pulse stuttered. She seemed unable to pull her gaze away. Then, finally, she blinked and all was normal again. Still, the grip of fear kept its clutch around her heart.

The air shifted, sudden and cold, the way it had when the moonlight had thinned. For one blink, the bedroom phased to the moment the black fissures had webbed across her own forearms, golden sparks inverting, darkness sucking the air from her lungs. Then Adora felt the tremors again, bones vibrating at the exact frequency of the shadow’s laugh. She heard the crack of glass as the photo frame smashed. Then the morning light resettled, and shattering glass and darkening fissures were just the memory of sensations that hadn’t really resurfaced in the first place.

Catra cupped her cheek, and Adora wanted to both lean into the touch and recoil. She did neither, just staying totally still. She truly did not deserve this comfort. She was unworthy of this persistent love.

Catra shifted closer, trying again. “Last night, I thought I was going to lose you.” Her voice snagged on the last words, raw and real.

The truth pressed against Adora’s ribs like a weight. She should have. Adora deserved to be gone. That would be better. The thoughts sank in, and her chest tightened until it felt like it might crack.

“You can't fight this alone, Adora. You have to-”

“I can't fight it at all.” The words slipped out on a shaky exhale. “It’s stronger than me, and it’s right.” Adora’s voice shrank toward the end, barely a whisper.

Catra’s expression pinched, in slightly frustrated confusion, and one ear flicked a bit irritably. “I don't understand what that means.”

“It doesn't matter,” Adora replied flatly, her eyes drifting away again, unfocused

Catra just exhaled slowly, her tail giving a sharp flick. She left the room, and when she returned, she set a tray down on the bedside table. She tried to coax Adora to eat or drink anything, but Adora just stared listlessly. Catra’s words blurred now into the gray of the room. Adora made out a whispered, “Please,” so soft and desperate before Catra left again.

Melog entered, its glow dimming as it sensed Adora’s emotional unease. It settled close beside the bed. Watching her, guarding her for Catra. Hours passed that way, time stretching thin.

The day passed in fragments of consciousness. Light shifted from gray to dull gold to light blue outside the windows, and sunbeams crawled across the floor, and Adora barely saw them. She lost track of time for hours. The faint scent of the fruit she hadn’t touched lingered in the air. Soft sounds of the castle filtered in mutedly, as if coming from underwater, phasing in and out like the flickers from a tracker pad transmission losing its signal.

Adora didn’t budge. Her limbs felt numb. Movement required intention, and she didn’t seem to have any left. Her body felt both heavy and hollow at once. Every so often, she became aware of her own breathing, still painful from the magic of the night before. Then even that slipped away.

Her thoughts turned bleak. She had ruined her life. She had succumbed to the darkness. She deserved to be replaced by Etheria. Maybe Etheria should find someone better, someone stronger than her. Someone who wouldn’t hurt everything they loved by existing wrong.

The world seemed to tilt around her as that thought took root. The light dimmed suddenly as if darkened by a storm rolling in. A pulse of cold swept through the room. Adora’s own shadow blackened and rippled across the bed. As if drawn to it, Adora shifted until she had risen and was standing pressed against the

side of the bed. Shadow She-Ra peeled upward and solidified, looming before Adora.

Her sharp outline. Her bright, glowing eyes. She radiated with the power that Adora now lacked. Shadow She Ra appeared undamaged in any way, stronger if anything. Whole and unscarred by last night's magic.

Melog's glow snapped from dull to sharp and jagged flickers of red. It let out a soft growl.

A voice seemed to come from within Adora's skin and echo through her in a low, resonant tone. "You can't burn me out. I live in your bones."

Adora couldn't move, couldn't breathe. Her pulse stuttered, and her hands trembled against the edge of the bed. She felt caught in the grip of the horror of the quiet certainty of the shadow that only grew stronger no matter what she did. She tasted the metallic tang of fear on her tongue. Tears appeared on her cheeks that she hadn't even known had fallen.

Before Adora could speak, the form unraveled into smoke that dissolved back into the corners of the room. She vanished like she had never even appeared. Adora's breath stuttered, a ripple of panic pulsed through her, and her vision swam. For one blink, the low, familiar hum that always accompanied transformation echoed in her ears. Then, for a heartbeat, the floor seemed to dip beneath her, just slightly and almost impossibly, as if something had shifted below.

Adora sank onto the bed and tried to ground herself by thinking of something that felt safe. Nothing felt like it would ever be safe again. Instead, she tried to focus on an object in the room that felt neutral. They all seemed to judge. The clutter on the dresser that she hadn't sorted, the crack in the ceiling she hadn't repaired, everything around her asked for something she felt incapable of giving. She had nothing left to give now, not to anyone or anything.

Late afternoon light turned the color of diluted honey. It pooled on the floor like something spilled, not something given. Adora still lay numb and unrousable when Catra returned to their bedroom. Adora couldn’t summon the will to speak or even really look at her, but she still caught a flicker of real fear in Catra’s dual-colored eyes before her wife turned away to head back into the main room of their suite to greet their kids. Adora wanted to want to go to them.

A single drop of condensation slid down the side of the untouched water glass. It seemed to hit the wooden tray with a plop that jarred against the silence of the bedroom. To Adora, it felt like the sound of a gavel falling, pronouncing a sentence on the day.

Soon, Adora heard her family having dinner. Muffled laughter drifted through the wall. The higher pitches seemed clipped, leaving only the hollow beats. The absence of the fully joyful tones hurt more than the silence would have. Still, any form of laughter was a sound from a life that she no longer deserved.

Then, she heard the kids getting ready for bed, but still she couldn’t bring herself to leave her bed or move even a muscle. As the whispered goodnights faded through the wall, Adora heard Catra pad back in and sink onto the bed beside her. Hands hesitated for a moment, and then Adora felt the touch of claws lightly grazing her scalp in slow strokes. Catra leaned in as if to press a kiss to Adora’s temple, but then pulled back as if afraid it would be rebuffed.

“I don't want to watch you destroy yourself, Adora.” Catra’s voice was laced with care and pain.

“I’m already destroyed,” Adora whispered, “You should let me go.”

Catra inhaled sharply, like the words physically hurt her. Her ears flattened, and the tip of her tail trembled against the sheets. Then, after a moment, she resumed her careful stroking.

“No,” Catra asserted with all the love she could muster. “You’re still here, Adora. That matters.”

Adora didn’t respond, but something in her chest trembled. It felt like the barest flicker of warmth trying desperately to spark against the cold. Catra lay down beside her, tail wrapping Adora’s ankle.

Adora’s hands trembled from the aftershock of the shadow. Still, she curled her pinky toward Catra’s. The smallest gesture, almost like an involuntary reflex, but actually the first intentional motion she had made in hours. She let her next inhale match the cadence of Catra’s, a shared breath. Adora didn’t fight sleep when it came.

Chapter 10

Morning came slow, tender, and unexpectedly warm. Gentle light drifted into the bedroom and across the floorboards in soft golden ribbons. The quiet felt different than the day before. It wasn't as sharp or pressing. It felt like someone had turned the volume down on reality, letting it feel just a little bit softer today. Adora had expected pain or panic to greet her upon waking, but instead she just felt… present.

She felt the comfort of the blankets wrapped around her. She felt the softness of her pillow beneath her cheek. She felt the gentle weight of the tail curled around her ankle as if anchoring her to this world. It all contrasted with the oppressive heaviness of the day before.

For the first time in what seemed like ages, she inhaled without flinching. A thin, fragile thread of warmth spread through her chest, radiating like a pulse of sunlight. It was small and fleeting, but real. She clung to the feeling, not letting it slip away. As she stirred more fully awake, she felt the smallest flash of gratitude.

“I’m still here,” she whispered to herself, barely more than a breath, as if saying it too loudly might break this moment.

She didn't move yet. She lay perfectly still, letting herself notice the shape of her body in the blankets and the calming coolness of the morning air on her face. She held onto the fact that she had awoken at all when she had been so close to letting herself succumb to her own deepest darkness.

As she settled into her awareness, she sensed a faint echo of emptiness from below the floor. For a heartbeat, it was almost as if the floor had dropped out from beneath the bed. There was a hollow tug far below Bright Moon. She instinctively pushed away from that sensation, focusing instead on the touch of Catra’s tail still wrapped around her ankle. She let that ground her back to the current moment.

Slowly, the details of the room around her took form. The faint smell of singed magic was all but gone now. It had been replaced by the familiar smells of their Bright Moon bedroom, the usual fresh, earthy scent with its underlying mineral elements, a mix of waterfall mist, plants, and crystals.

Her thoughts drifted to the day before, a small wave of shame flickering through her. Adora let herself blink it away. Instead, she shifted her head just enough to see Catra sitting up on the other side of the bed.

Catra was leaning against the headboard with her legs curled up and her hands resting over them. Her fur was ruffled, and she had faint shadows under her eyes, like she had been too worried to sleep well. Catra's ears were angled slightly forward, alert but not anxious. She was looking at Adora with calm, steady concern.

Adora opened her mouth before she could really even think.

"I'm sorry."

The words tumbled out in a quiet rush. She didn't even know if she was apologizing for the day before or the way she had been unraveling for weeks. Adora tightened her shoulders a bit, bracing herself for Catra's response, for the potential disappointment or anger she feared might come.

They looked at each other for a beat. Catra's ears twitched. She relaxed her hand where she had been pressing her claws into her palm. Her claws retracted fully. Catra exhaled slowly, her shoulders loosening, and shook her head definitively.

"You don't have to apologize for hurting, Adora," she said firmly, but with underlying softness.

Adora, unable to meet her gaze, glanced toward the floorboards. A faint tremor seemed to pulse through the floor. So small she would've thought she imagined it, except Catra's ears flicked sideways at the exact same instant. Adora looked quickly away. Her body seemed impossibly heavy, like she was waking from

years of exhaustion and not just a few nights. She inhaled shakily and forced a breath into her lungs to stabilize herself.

"I don't want to feel like this anymore," Adora said in a small voice. "I… I'm scared of what I've let happen, and that I still don't know how to make it stop."

Catra was listening intently, her full attention on Adora. Her tail gave a small twitch, but then resettled.

Adora tried to continue speaking, but the right words were hard to find. Shame kept rising, thick and stifling. Catra stayed silently supportive, not pushing. She waited with the patience Adora needed to allow herself to gain the strength to continue.

Finally, with an exhale that was like stepping off a cliff, Adora said, "It's been hard for me for a while now. I've felt adrift from my life… like I've been watching it, not living it."

The words had started hesitantly, but now began to just pour out in a rush.

"It has seemed like no matter what I do, I'm doing it wrong. I couldn't escape my spiraling thoughts, and I was trying to just punch them out a few nights ago, when my shadow… solidified. It… it was like a dark version of She-Ra had formed. It said I had to fix myself or it would finish the job."

Adora swallowed hard, her throat tight.

"The shadow kept growing stronger as I felt worse and worse."

Once more, Adora suddenly saw the glass frame shattering off the wall, the dark fissures wrapping around her arms, and the cruel laughter of Shadow She-Ra echoing in her ears. She shivered but shook off the memories.

Catra's ears flattened. A low involuntary growl slipped out. Her eyes flicked sharply, afraid Adora would think it was directed at

her. Adora's fingers found hers and squeezed, assuring Catra she knew the growl was for the shadow.

She felt more than saw Catra's tail coil in tight, her claws flexing instinctively against the sheets before retracting again. Adora could sense her wife's stirring emotions at this disclosure, a mix of fear and anger at the shadow and at herself for not having known better how to help, along with her deep aching love. The weight of what Adora had said hung in the space between them, a truth heavy enough that it almost seemed to warp the air around them.

Adora stared at the wall. She almost stopped talking right there. Then, she steeled herself and pushed herself to continue to express it all.

Her voice grew small again as she admitted, "I think Etheria wants a different She-Ra. It deserves a better She-Ra than me." Her voice cracked on the last words, and she paused to draw in a ragged breath.

Catra had gone still beside her, so still, Adora could hear the faint hitch in her breath.

"I hid this because I didn't want to believe it was real. I wanted it to be just in my head… something I could just stop believing in and it wouldn't exist."

She hesitated and then added in a whisper barely more than a breath, "There were moments where I thought… maybe it would be better if I wasn't here anymore."

Catra's ears snapped flat. Her next inhale was a sound Adora had never heard from her before. It was like a strangled sob. Adora looked over and saw heartbreak etched in every line of her face. Catra's hands shook. Her dual-colored eyes glistened with pain she wasn't even trying to hide.

Catra inched herself slowly over toward Adora, like she wanted to make sure she didn't startle her, but was desperate to offer her

physical comfort. She cupped her cheek, and Adora felt her thumb trembling against her skin.

Catra's voice when she finally spoke was soft, but so full of love, "You never should've had to hold that alone."

Adora collapsed forward, her forehead pressed against Catra's shoulder as her breath became a silent sob. Catra caught her immediately, arms strong around her back and her tail twisting tighter around her ankle like a vow. She held Adora snugly to her as Adora cried softly in her arms, tears soaking into her shirt.

Catra rocked Adora subtly, a tiny, almost imperceptible motion, like she was trying to remind Adora that her body existed and still belonged here. The warmth of Catra around her seeped slowly in until Adora's own trembling synced with Catra's steadier rhythm. Outside birds called, soft and hesitant.

Catra whispered soft comforts under her breath, "I've got you now… It's going to be okay." Her hands stroked through Adora's hair calmly.

After a few moments, Catra pressed gently under her chin, using two fingers to lift her face up so she could look in her eyes. Adora let herself be guided.

As their eyes met, Catra said with quiet force, "Etheria doesn't need a new She-Ra. It needs you, all of you." Catra's mismatched eyes were filled with her honest admiration as she added, "Don't forget how you've changed so many things for the better just by caring and trying."

Adora felt something inside her cracking open, not painfully, but like a locked door finally giving way.

Catra held her tighter, and her voice softened further. "You're not just She-Ra, Adora. You're my person. You mean everything to me."

Adora shook her head, and more tears streamed freely down her cheeks. “I feel broken.”

Catra placed both hands on either side of her face, holding her with a fierce tenderness. “A broken person doesn’t feel this deeply. A broken person wouldn’t have kept reaching, kept trying.”

Her thumbs brushed Adora’s damp cheeks.

“You’re overwhelmed because you care, not because you’re damaged.”

The words sank into Adora slowly, like warmth spreading through frozen limbs and reinvigorating them. She shuddered once, like a soft and involuntary release. She let herself believe, even just for a heartbeat, that maybe she wasn't as fundamentally flawed as she had started to fear.

Catra eased them both back down onto the bed once more. She pulled Adora gently back into her arms and wrapped her tail around her ankle again. Adora lay her head on Catra’s chest. Catra wound her arms around Adora, enclosing her in safety. Adora felt a wave of warmth fill her as she let herself be held. Adora breathed in the scent of her, warm fur and something musky and a bit sweet that she couldn't quite name. The room settled around her again.

“I’m glad I woke up,” Adora whispered into Catra’s shirt. The words felt too small for what they conveyed, but they were true.

Catra froze for the briefest moment before holding her even tighter, like she would do anything to keep Adora tethered to the world. Adora’s shoulders loosened, and her muscles unclenched. The rhythm of Catra’s heartbeat against her cheek steadied her. She inhaled deeply, and for the first time in days, the air went all the way in without catching. It moved fully, smoothly and freely through her.

Catra’s exhale stuttered, barely audible, like she’d been holding her breath since yesterday. Her breath brushed against Adora’s

hair.

Beyond their rooms, Bright Moon was waking. The sounds of soft voices in the halls as guard shifts changed over, the clink of someone starting the early morning preparations of food for the dining hall, and the faint trickle of water running through the castle channels all drifted gently through the walls. It felt calm and politely distant, like Etheria was giving her space to rediscover her place in the world again.

Catra’s thumb traced slow patterns along her arm, small shapes that could map her back to a fuller existence. Every circle said, you’re still here. Every soft breath against her cheek seemed to say, stay. For the first time in days, maybe even weeks, Adora thought she could do that. She reached for the water glass on the table beside her. It shook slightly in her hand and clinked against her teeth, but she swallowed a large sip before setting it back down, its clean mineral taste lingering on her tongue.

Light shifted across the bed as Adora let herself relax fully against Catra, her thoughts drifting. She didn't know yet how to truly live with all the heaviness inside of her. She didn't know the best way to heal the parts of her that still hurt. She knew that healing would take time, but she wanted to try. Wanting to live might not be the same as knowing how, but it was a start. Now, at least she knew that she definitely wanted that again.

Catra’s tail unwound from her ankle and brushed lightly against her calf, no longer an anchor but a promise of support. Adora drew in one last steadying breath and swung her legs over the side of the bed. The floorboards were cool beneath her bare feet, real and solid. Somewhere beneath, she felt a sharp vibration, like an echo of distant magic resonating from below, but she stood up anyway, taking one step forward.

Chapter 11

The gray of early dawn filled the bedroom with a hint of dim softness. The first band of morning sunshine filtered through the window and crawled across the floor until it reached her own bare feet, just lighting up her toes with an inch of golden glow and the slightest brush of warmth on her skin. Adora realized that the light was waiting for her. It didn't have to be earned. It just existed.

She drew in a breath and called for her shadow, “Come now. I’m ready for you.”

Shadow She-Ra appeared as a silhouette with wavering edges against the smooth stone of the bedroom wall.

Adora spoke to her, “You’re me. You’re the part that I hide from, that is scared and sad. I accept that now.” She pressed her hand to the Shadow’s hand.

Her own voice, but distant, echoed through her. “To reintegrate me, you must walk the Hollow. Right now, you are too fractured to stand and to hold up the sword. Just survival is not enough. There is a place beneath you. I know you’ve felt its pull. It is the hollow in your foundation that you have been falling toward. You can’t join the world fully again until you walk the place beneath it. Come find me where you buried yourself.”

Adora’s hand shook. She closed her eyes, steeling herself. Then, she nodded and stated firmly, “Yes, it’s time.”

At those words, the floor beneath her rippled, and the room dimmed. The floorboards groaned, and a crack widened as an opening appeared. Adora’s stomach dropped. She sensed that this was a place she must enter alone, and that there was a danger she could become trapped forever.

Catra was at her side now, barefoot, her hair undone. She reached for Adora’s arm, her ears flicking downward. “I just got

you back.” Her voice was a low whisper. Her claws flexed and then retracted.

Adora looked at her meaningfully. “If you come, I’ll be following your belief in me instead of my own. All my life, I’ve chased others' expectations instead of mine.”

Catra’s fingers slipped from Adora’s wrist slowly, reluctantly, like she was releasing the knob of a door she had been forced to close too soon.

Adora then entered the Hollow, alone and willingly. Her foot sank into the nothingness and felt suddenly formless. The floor instantly dropped into darkness. Pressure built in her ears. She fell slowly downward, like sinking into something viscous. Wisps of memories floated around her, vibrating subtly where they touched against her skin.

Then, she felt the firm presence of a stone walkway cool beneath her bare feet, suspended in the endless dark. Her heartbeat was muffled in her ears, and her breath fogged with each exhale. The distant sound of a drip came from afar. The air carried a mineral chill laced with the faintest ghost of Catra’s musky sweet smell just barely drifting in from up above.

With her first step forward, a dim pulse of light emitted from below her foot. It cast the Hollow in a brief bit of faint light. It lit only in the moment of the after-glow of her step before fading quickly back into deep darkness.

The pungent, yet so familiar, smell of burnt refuse infused the air with an acrid scent. Harsh, resonant, metallic clangs now filled her ears. Her shoulders instinctively squared, like she was readying to salute. It was as if she were back in the Fright Zone of her childhood.

“Do not let something like this happen again.” Shadow Weaver’s deep, distinctive voice suddenly echoed all around her. The sharp edges were swallowed by the vastness of the Hollow.

Adora's heartbeat raced, and her eyes darted about looking for the floating form of the woman whom she hadn't seen in so many years. She had died so long ago. Still, just her mere memory filled Adora with a mix of so many emotions.

Instead, though, Adora saw only the negative space depiction of General Juliet sitting in the briefing room, a black silhouette backlit by an aura of light before forming like a miniature full-color scene hovering before her eyes. A tabletop map zoomed in on Thaymor and the disturbance at their market with an overturned stall. A child's stuffed toy was crushed beneath it.

General Juliet's voice rang out, "You had left a sector far too short-staffed."

"I should've caught that," Adora immediately chastised herself in a soft whisper. The depicted stall went up in flames. She felt the heat of them on her face. The crackling of the wood as it was set ablaze.

"I put people at risk," she muttered aloud, the guilt weighing on her as she watched the stand burn, and then the flames started to spread to the next stall. The stuffed toy melted away.

"I should have prevented this," Adora said in a distraught whisper. Two more buildings were now ablaze. The flickering light of the flames cast shifting shadows across Adora's face. The smell of smoke permeated the air.

Shadow She-Ra's voice called from all around her, "Look at what you're doing. Say it aloud."

Adora stared at the spreading blaze that had grown from her own spiraling guilt. "I'm using a small, standard mistake as evidence I'm unfit to exist. I was taught mistakes were failings of character, not moments to learn from, and I've never been able to let mine go."

The flames froze in mid-burn. The market was back to just a single overturned stand. Adora realized that Shadow Weaver's

lessons had outlived the Horde, outlived the War, and had become so entrenched in her worldview that she still fought against them every day.

Shadow She-Ra's voice echoed through her, "To walk forward, you must face the parts of yourself you've been unable to accept. Every step asks you to move past a belief that has held you down."

She felt the Hollow pulling at her motivation. The love she'd just received from Catra flickered within her, drifting away even as she tried to hold onto the feeling. This was a place built exactly from where she might break. The Hollow tested whether she would press on or turn back.

She whispered, "I'm scared." Still, she kept moving forward, ready now to face what she needed to face to truly live again.

Shadow She-Ra said, "The exit will only open if you can name me with truth."

"I don't know what that means," Adora said softly.

"Then keep walking."

Adora stepped forward.

A garden, golden at sunset, appeared hovering before her. The heady perfume of roses hung in the air. The low hush of a breeze drifted through the flowers, the sound exactly like Catra's slowed exhale when she was trying not to cry. A rosebud hung upside down, its petals curling and falling off as if it were both blooming and dying at once, like beauty suspended by the promise of imminent collapse.

"I don't even know how to reach you anymore." Catra's low, raspy voice echoed through the space. "For a minute there, I thought of just bailing."

The garden path forked. On the left, Catra walked away into an over-exposed landscape where the colors bleached out to white in the distance. Her silhouette shrank into the blown-out brightness, and she left no footprints behind like she had already been erased. On the right, Catra stood still, and sparks of Adora's uncontrolled magic crawled across her arm in a landscape that was under-exposed in tones of deep burnt umber. The acrid smell of singed fur filled the air.

Catra's voice rang out, "Choose one, Adora. I leave you, or I stay, and you kill me."

Adora realized that deep inside, she believed that if she wasn't perfect, love would vanish. As she stared at the scene before her, the sparking magic suddenly jumped onto Catra's chest, and she collapsed. Adora lunged for her and cradled her limp body in her arms. She felt the coarse tangle of her wife's thick hair rough against her palm as she threaded her fingers through it and held onto her desperately. Catra's pulse was thready but still there. The scent of roses was tinged now with iron.

"Face your fear," the layered version of her own voice echoed.

"I will do something wrong, and it'll make her leave me forever," Adora confessed in a quiet rush. Catra suddenly felt weightless in her arms, her heartbeat snuffed out as suddenly as a candle's glow.

Adora looked down at Catra's too still face and lowered her gently to the ground with shaking hands. She somehow managed to step forward, and the illusion faded, still the image lingered in her mind, something she couldn't easily shake.

She had reached the center now. The darkness thickened. Her footstep reverberated. She heard her own distant voice around and through her. "You want to live now. You had your chance, and you threw it away! You don't deserve a second beginning."

Adora sank to one knee and felt like she should give up and turn back. But then, she felt Catra's presence and support still with her. Catra's heartbeat and her faint scent drifted toward her from far above. These strengthened Adora to keep going. She forced herself forward one small step.

An image of a cradle made from She-Ra's shield appeared before her. It rocked itself back and forth in a steady rhythm. Inside, a trio of faceless, wood-carved babies screamed ceaselessly each time Adora blinked or looked away. They had minuscule cat ears and golden, copper, and ginger hair just like Finn, Cole, and Rosra.

The words, "I can't feel what I'm supposed to feel," repeated over and over in a low vibration.

Adora took in those words and then steeled herself to challenge them. "I kept waiting for the right feeling instead of giving them the flawed me that was already here. They don't need perfection, just me."

As soon as those words had left her, the screaming faded into a hiccuping sigh. The babies quieted, their ears tilting in curiosity instead of distress. Then, the shield cradle faded away into nothingness as Adora stepped forward.

She now saw a hall of mirrors before her, and each reflection of her was distorted. She saw a version that was cruel and dangerous, with hardened eyes and in full Horde armor, one that was beyond fragile with caved shoulders and eyes brimming with tears, and one that was too perfect and unachievable, with armor pristinely polished and expression blankly serene. They flickered as she breathed.

"Pick one," a voice reverberated through the air.

Adora knew better now than to do as commanded, and she said instead, "They are all versions of me that I fear. Every reflection of

me has just been someone I've performed, and none is the true me."

The mirrors shattered inward, towards her. Adora's knees buckled, though she remained standing. The shards stuck together and fused into Shadow She-Ra. For a moment, the silhouette was mosaic-ed with jagged Adoras before they faded into its standard black, but her same height and with no aura this time. She was more like a solidified shadow version of Adora herself now.

"Tell me the truth you've never said aloud. The one that made me… or the Hollow keeps us," the voice echoed through her.

"Your name is mine," Adora stated and paused for a moment before adding. "I kept sharpening my own pain because if I bled alone, no one would see the parts of me that are missing."

The shadow flickered, and they faced each other as equals. "Now you know me."

The shadow dissolved back into her, integrated. She felt whole and a bit strange as the shadow settled into place within her.

"I choose the mess, I choose the risk, I choose to keep breathing," Adora whispered lowly to herself.

A doorway appeared. Adora was shaking and drained. She had a sudden instinct to glance behind, but she pushed that back and instead she stepped through, grateful to be alive. She had named her shadow, she wanted to live, and she had earned her way out. She was ready, even if just barely, to rejoin the world.

Dawn was now full gold. Catra hadn't moved. Adora let her weight settle until they were leaning shoulder to shoulder, two imperfect angles finding a third, steadier shape. Their shadows overlapped at a single jagged seam. The same sunlight that had touched against her toes now lit up both of them, warm and steady. Their breath synced softly.

Catra whispered, "Welcome home, Adora."

The words settled over her like a tide creating driftwood, steady and patient and shaped anew from something wrecked. Adora exhaled with relief, the sound of someone truly coming home and finally leaving the one she had been locked inside. She was choosing this life now rather than performing it to perfection.

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The patter of little feet on the floorboards carried from just beyond their bedroom door. It was not just noise today, but a rhythm of forgotten joy finally reaching her. Adora realized with relief that she truly wanted to be with her children again. That just her presence would be enough for them, and all they really wanted was time with her.

She gave Catra's hand a soft squeeze, reassurance and thanks wrapped together in that one small gesture. Then, they both headed into the main room of their suite, Adora in the lead. Sun-warmed crystals lit up the space, and the trickle of fresh running water trailed in the background.

"Mama, you're awake!" Rosra burst out, rushing toward her with tangled ginger waves bobbing about her face and clutching her favorite stuffed toy. Her tail swished all about in her delight. Adora pulled her in for a quick squeeze. As she straightened, Adora noticed her own shadow stretching behind her, now not something to fear but just proof that she was standing in the light.

Cole stood nearby, bouncing on his heels, his copper hair rumpled from sleep. Finn stood beside him, his golden hair sticking up a bit on one side. They both looked up at her eagerly.

Adora smiled genuinely at them and said, "Let's all sit and have a bite to eat."

Adora gently guided them toward the table and plated some toast and fruit for each child. Then, she sat down to eat right alongside them. Rosra clambered up onto her chair, sitting on her knees, tail swishing in excited arcs. Cole lined up his pieces of toast and dollops of jam, readying them for a tasty science experiment. Finn

watched them both quietly with the air of an older sibling who was above their antics, but still secretly engaged.

Catra passed Adora a cup of hot tea, which Adora cradled in both hands, letting its heat ground her. Lifting it, she felt the gentle steam waft comfortingly across her face. She spread jam onto a piece of toast and took a bite, its sweetness bright on her tongue.

A few days ago, these moments would have played out for Adora like they were behind fogged glass. She would have felt overwhelmed by her inadequacy and let herself drift away rather than engage. Now, the fog was lifting, and she was inside again and not just watching.

Laughter rang out as Rosra made a silly little face with her fruit, and Adora smiled, really taking in the joyful sound. The sweet smell of fruit and jam filled the air. The clangs of dishes, the scrapes of chairs, Melog's padding footsteps, and the brush of the kids' tails were all still there, but now they felt alive instead of just grating.

"Were you sick?" Cole asked, his ears tilted back slightly and his golden eyes wide.

"I was tired in my heart, but I'm getting better, and you helped without even knowing," Adora replied.

They finished up their breakfast, and Adora worked as a team with Catra to get the kids ready for their lessons. Adora helped Cole with a stubborn fastener while Catra pulled up Rosra's hair. Melog pressed against her legs, and Adora gave it a few soft pats.

Adora saw the still unmended toy lying on the ground. Her chest tightened for a moment, the familiar little voice of not enough still tugged at her like an undone stitch, but now she didn't let herself come fully unraveled with it. She reminded herself that just being here counted, and she let the shadow settle, a weight she could feel but that no longer pulled her down so fully.

As they headed for the door, three satchels bumped against three small shoulders. Adora didn't hesitate; she knelt down beside them and encircled her children in her arms. She felt their little arms around her own neck and shoulders, and Rosra’s sticky paw on her cheek.

Catra leaned in over the kids and pressed her forehead lightly to Adora’s over the tangle of hair and ears. Adora closed her eyes and let the feel of the hug land fully within her. This time, without the tally of what she hadn't done, but just the messy warmth of truly being there with them all.

Adora didn't rush anxiously to the training yard today. Instead, she walked calmly through the corridors of Bright Moon, grounding herself. With each footfall, she felt the polished floor solid beneath the soles of her boots.

Adora stepped out of the castle’s postern gate. The sky was a clear blue, bright and beautiful above her and the grass, a rich green carpet crunching beneath her feet. She felt the soft breeze and the steadily growing warmth of the day.

Approaching the yard, she noticed the gleam of armor reflecting the light, the clangs and shouts of the yard a steady song around her. Adora felt sturdy, her chest full now, not hollow. She paused in the shade of a nearby tree and observed.

Zira’s clear, confident voice filled the yard. “Shields up. Ryn, a bit higher to not leave your side open. That’s it. Now we move as one.”

Their line formed in a well-practiced maneuver, boots shifting in unison. Adora felt a small flutter in her stomach, and for a moment, she worried that maybe they didn't need her at all. Then she took a calming breath and let herself listen more fully.

Zira called out, “That’s better. We just need to be ready to adjust. If you get knocked off balance, just find it again. That’s what Commander Adora taught us.”

A stunned warmth filled Adora’s chest. She hadn't realized her words had sunk in like that. She felt a stitch of pride mending the ragged places that had been barely holding together. She realized she really had been giving them tools this whole time. She didn't need to always be the one in the center commanding. Now, she watched the guards she had trained hold their own.

“Break,” Zira announced.

The guards looked up and noticed Adora under the tree. Ryn straightened so fast his shield nearly flew from his grip.

“Relax,” Adora said, walking towards them with a small smile. “Your line looked good. Just remember, a shield shouldn't make you a wall but let you move.” She tapped the edge of his shield as she added, “You adjusted today, and that’s what matters.”

Ryn’s shoulders loosened, and the look he gave Zira said that her words and Adora’s had landed in the same place.

Adora turned to the edge of the yard as she heard the familiar rush of flapping wings. Swift Wind landed nearby and approached. She breathed in his grassy, sun-warm scent and noticed the soft rainbow glints from his wings.

“Adora, how are you? I’ve been so worried about you.” Swift Wind started and then added, “But sometimes I get carried away. I know you can handle things.”

Adora smiled, patting his neck gently as she shrugged. “Things are better. It’s not perfect, and I’m definitely still figuring it all out.”

Swift Wind nuzzled her affectionately. “Perfection is boring. You, though? Never boring.”

“Thanks, Swifty,” Adora replied.

She felt his care and didn't let it swirl into guilt this time. She didn't know exactly what she needed to be at every moment, but

she would keep figuring out the balance of where to let him in and where to stand on her own, shadow and all.

Her stomach grumbled loudly.

“I have some oats and apples if you’d like,” Swift Wind offered with an amused snort.

Adora laughed, “I think I might need a bit more than that.”

“Well, you go off to the dining hall then, and I’ll go back to my mission for equine equality!”

Adora gave him a last fond pat before he trotted off.

Entering the Bright Moon dining hall, sunlight slanted through the large, arched windows, and the comforting smells of familiar foods wafted through the air with hints of savory spices and fresh herbs. Adora took a large bowl of hearty stew and then scanned the room for an out-of-the-way table. Her eye caught Glimmer and Bow at one near a window, and Glimmer waved her over with her fork.

As she approached, Adora felt her shoulders tense and a flicker of anxiety that they might have been upset with her. Doubts still pricked at the back of her mind like tiny snags along a long seam. Her grip tightened on her tray.

Bow wordlessly shifted over to make room for her with an easy smile. Glimmer's relaxed posture set her further at ease as she sat down beside them. Her friends were steady and welcoming as always.

“Adora, how are you?” Bow asked as he pressed a comforting hand to her shoulder.

Adora slid her tray onto the table, her plate clinking from the slight unsteadiness in her hands. Bow casually nudged a basket of bread toward her in wordless reassurance.

Glimmer added, “You don't have to tell us everything. But just know we’re here for you when you need it.”

Adora nodded. For half a heartbeat, the old urge to just say she was fine rose up like a reflex, but instead she answered honestly. “Yeah, it's been a lot lately, but I’m doing better now. I’m taking things slower.” She exhaled softly and glanced between them.

Halfway through the meal, Adora realized that she had stopped bracing herself for accusations that never came. She took her last bite of stew and noticed how it sat warm and filling in her stomach. Bow’s arms looped around them, and they all leaned in for a quick hug. Adora felt its comfort surge through her.

Adora left the dining hall feeling a renewed sense of connection. She hadn't pushed off interaction out of overwhelm but just let herself live in the moment, and that was enough for now. She didn't need to have every plan decided. Even when the whispers of doubt stirred, she could lean into the small moments and just try to make the most of them. They didn't need more than that. They were her best friends, and their support was there when she needed it to help keep her patched together, snags and all.

Adora headed back to the training yard for an afternoon of weapons practice with her guards. Their forms were sharp and focused as they moved through the rotation. Adora moved among them, calling out adjustments and demonstrating a pivot here, a parry there.

Then, Adora heard the soft thud of armor against dirt and a sharp intake of breath from the neighboring yard. One of the young guards had gone down hard, clutching her ankle. Adora’s body moved before she could even think.

She-Ra could help. The thought settled over her like something simple and true. Of course, she would help. Of course, she could. Still, her heart gave a quick, uneven stutter, remembering magic gone wrong. She pushed past it. Thrusting her arm outward, she called forth her magic.

Warmth spread from deep within her, starting at her core and radiating outward to her fingertips. The magic flowed smoothly and unbroken. As the light surged, she braced for fissures and fractures, but instead, like a golden thread running through patchwork, her light knit together the gaps and held them together. Her transformation took hold.

Her magic felt right again, calm and controlled. Her shadow was beside her, aligned, steady at her feet, following her motions instead of leading them. Her heartbeat was synced with the golden light. The magic didn't demand anything from her now. It just met her. It was hers again, no longer an adversary, but a true part of her once more.

She reached toward the fallen guard, letting her warmth surge into the injured ankle and healing it fully. She let the transformation drop and saw Catra and their kids approaching the yard. As the last day moon drifted below the horizon, filling the sky with streaks of pink, the kids began to play with wooden swords beside the guards.

Finn tried to mimic Zira’s stance and nearly toppled when Rosra barreled into him. Cole swung his sword toward her in playful retaliation. Wooden blades knocked together with harmless clacks, and the kids' laughter echoed off stone walls in bright bursts.

Catra and Adora stepped off to the side of the yard. Their shadows overlapped naturally as they leaned into one another. Adora felt the mix of lingering adrenaline mingled with the fatigue of a long day, but she didn't let it overwhelm her. The shadow in her bones was ever-present but settled now.

“How do you feel?” Catra asked, her ears slightly pitched forward and her tail curling around Adora’s leg.

“The heaviness... the shadow, it's still there… and I don't think it will ever fully disappear,” Adora admitted softly.

“Yeah,” Catra murmured, “I kind of figured.”

“It feels different, though,” Adora continued. “Less like it's dragging me down and more like something I’m holding while I keep walking.”

“Good,” Catra replied. “Then we’ll walk with it, not for it.” Then she added tenderly, “You don't have to be fixed to be mine.”

Catra tugged her closer, and Adora leaned in, not in collapse but choosing closeness. Their fingers threaded together. Adora didn't brace for the worst but reached for the life she wanted and let it hold her, all of her, messy and real and imperfect. The seams were still a little jagged, but they held, and that was enough.

Adora tightened her hand around Catra’s and decided, quietly and completely, to stay. When Adora glanced down, she saw her shadow, Catra’s shadow, and three smaller shapes darting in and out of them as the kids ran past. They overlapped, then separated and crossed again, shifting with the light but never disappearing. The clangs of training and the peals of laughter from the children wove together now into a new rhythm, one Adora had chosen and was finally ready to keep.



Chapter End Notes

Thank you for completing this journey with me! I poured my heart into this story, and it has helped me so much on my own ongoing journey with self-doubt, overwhelm and depression. I hope it can help anyone going through similar struggles feel a little less alone, and keep their hope alive that though our shadows may never disappear, we can stay and keep trying, even when it's messy. I will be sharing more Adora comfort stories soon!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!